

The Winner Premium^{*}

Patrick A. Testa[†]

September 1, 2026

Abstract

Election outcomes are treated as binary—winners are celebrated, while losers are mourned—even when margins convey little information about underlying support. This paper develops a framework in which the salience of winning versus losing generates differential political investment, converting narrow and potentially arbitrary outcomes into persistent advantages. I study this “winner premium” using counties in presidential elections, where outcomes carry symbolic importance yet impact neither the national results nor local office or policy. Focusing on a period of intense partisan realignment between 1940 and 1968, I find that counties where Democrats narrowly won the presidential vote subsequently experienced pronounced increases in Democratic local officeholding and voter support. These effects, which were largest in urban, Black, and union areas, operate through political investment—including voter registration advertising, direct voter outreach, and civil rights organizing. The findings show how elections not only reveal support, but also direct resources that help produce it.

Keywords: contests, electoral competition, political investment, coordination, voting, regression discontinuity design.

JEL Codes: D72, J15, J18, N32, N42, P16.

^{*}I am grateful to Desmond Ang, Brian Beach, Leah Boustan, Bill Collins, Andy Ferrara, Martin Fiszbein, Walker Hanlon, Eric Hilt, Elliott Isaac, Davis Kedrosky, Benjamin Marx, Doug Nelson, Thomas Pearson, Nancy Qian, Michael Ricks, Cole Williams, and Jhacova Williams as well as seminar participants at UC Irvine, UN Lincoln, Northwestern University, Tulane University, Vanderbilt University, and the 2026 NBER DAE Spring Meeting for comments and conversations that inspired and improved this paper. I also acknowledge and thank Thomas Pearson and Faiz Essa for data originally collected for a concurrent project. All errors are my own.

[†]Tulane University, Department of Economics and Murphy Institute, and NBER. Email: ptesta@tulane.edu.

1 Introduction

Winners in politics tend to keep winning. Some of that is mechanical—those who win hold office, set policy, and control political instruments with which to entrench themselves. Yet winning also comes with a less tangible return: the premium attached to being *named* the winner. Even where the margin is a single vote, the label confers status and momentum that can push winners and losers onto diverging paths (Anagol and Fujiwara, 2016; Granzier et al., 2023). That effect extends beyond the individual winner, with spillovers for their broader cohort (e.g., political party) in later contests (Baskaran and Hessami, 2018; Jackson, 1983). This paper isolates this “winner premium” and traces its impact on the trajectory of the Democratic Party as American politics realigned in the mid-twentieth century.

To begin, I develop a general framework for the mechanisms through which the label of winning alone can boost downstream political fortunes. The first mechanism concerns the *behavioral salience* of rank in the short term. When an electoral outcome is announced, winners are celebrated, while losers are mourned—even in close contests where rank conveys little information about underlying support. Over the longer term, this asymmetry feeds into a second mechanism: differential *strategic investment* based on rank. By energizing winners and demobilizing losers, electoral outcomes concentrate disproportionate resources among winners and their supporters. Because this holds even for the narrowest of wins, such investment can turn an all-but-arbitrary outcome into a real advantage, thus vindicating its initial salience.

Isolating the winner premium empirically is complicated by the various “spoils” of winning that affect future political performance, such as incumbency (De Benedictis-Kessner, 2018; Eggers and Spirling, 2017; De Magalhães, 2015). To overcome these challenges, I exploit the fact that *counties* primarily administer presidential elections in the U.S.—coordinating poll workers, overseeing polling sites, and canvassing vote totals—yet have no bearing on the higher-level electoral outcome. For instance, a can-

didate can win or lose a county by a single vote without changing the state’s electoral vote allocation. Nevertheless, counties have historically been viewed as bellwethers of party success writ large, particularly in periods of weaker partisan attachments ([Gimpel et al., 2022](#)). As such, a party’s performance in a county can carry symbolic importance despite conferring no local office or policy.

The analysis focuses on the county-level performance of the Democratic Party in presidential elections between 1940 and 1968—a period of intense political realignment in U.S. history. Demographic shifts during the Great Migration, combined with changes in national party platforms following the New Deal, brought urban and minority areas into play for the Democratic Party after 1936 ([Calderon et al., 2019](#); [Schickler, 2016](#)). I show that counties where Democrats won the presidential vote experienced sharp increases in Democratic support and officeholding subsequently, even though presidential outcomes themselves did not directly alter local offices.

Using a regression discontinuity (RD) design based on close presidential vote shares in counties from 1940 to 1968, I estimate the causal effect of a Democratic popular vote win on changes in Democratic political performance. The results indicate that a Democratic (close) popular-vote win in a county boosted the (relative) number of both Democratic local officeholders and presidential voters over the subsequent election period—consistent with about 9.6 (9.1) additional net Democratic officeholders (voters) per every 100 offices (votes) in the typical county. The results are robust to using (i) alternative RD specifications and bandwidths, (ii) flexible controls for county economic and demographic characteristics, and (iii) alternative samples based on region or opposition type. Meanwhile, an array of placebo exercises using (i) alternative RD thresholds and (ii) pre-treatment political trends fail to reject the null. These patterns are corroborated by micro-level evidence from the American National Election Studies (ANES), with higher levels of Democratic identification and registration among individuals—especially Black respondents—living in counties where Democrats most recently (narrowly) won the presidential vote.

To understand what drives these gains, I turn to the two mechanisms of the framework, beginning with the *behavioral salience* of winning. Based on newspaper coverage over the sample period, I build a daily index of celebratory versus mournful references to each party around election day. Independent of the vote margin, or of which party won the presidential election nationally, coverage of the county-level popular-vote winner turns sharply more celebratory—and that of the loser more mournful—immediately after the result, with no such gap beforehand. The shift is short-lived, fading within about two weeks, as one would expect of an expressive reaction to the binary outcome rather than a considered reading of the vote.

Differential *strategic investment* then plays out over the longer term. To show this, I first establish that the winner premium concentrates where the organizational infrastructure that underpinned Democratic Party investment was densest—such as counties with prior Democratic officeholders, NAACP chapters, and CIO union chapters—and falls to near zero elsewhere. I then trace the investment itself through its concrete channels. Party-directed voter registration advertising in local newspapers rises after a close win, building over the ensuing cycle toward the next presidential election. Along racial lines, investment ran both top-down—through direct outreach to Black voters and a roughly twofold rise in local civil rights organizing—and bottom-up, as Black migrants increasingly sorted into the counties the party had recently carried.

Finally, I ask how long the premium lasts and whether it mattered for the party's broader fortunes. First, an event study based on a county's first close Democratic win shows that the party's gains in officeholding and voter support persist for at least three election periods. Second, an illustrative account shows that the votes associated with the winner premium are large enough to have cost the Democrats their electoral college majority in the two close elections that they won, 1948 and 1960. Importantly, both put in office presidents—Truman and Kennedy, respectively—whose progressivism on civil rights helped set the party's subsequent course. Thus, compounded across a competitive map, the winner premium may have shaped not just the number of votes for each party

but the direction of the mid-century realignment.

This paper contributes to a growing literature on the effects of elections beyond their direct effects on political office and policy. Electoral outcomes can provoke behavioral responses and influence social coordination even when their direct consequences are limited (Baskaran and Hessami, 2018; Bochenkova et al., 2023; Ferreira and Gyourko, 2014; Egorov and Sonin, 2021; Little, 2017). Most relevant are Anagol and Fujiwara (2016) and Granzier et al. (2023), who show that candidate rank itself can affect subsequent political success, with publicly observed electoral outcomes serving as focal points for voters and political actors. Building on Testa and Williams (2025), this paper studies a setting in which the institutional consequences of winning are particularly limited—individual counties in presidential elections—where a party earns the designation of winner without gaining any corresponding office or policy authority. I show that this designation nevertheless provokes immediate behavioral responses with wide-ranging downstream political consequences, highlighting how elections matter beyond their role as a selection device.

Beyond social and behavioral effects, the results show how electoral outcomes can shape the allocation of political resources across places. Existing work documents such “political investment” through a range of channels, including campaign donors (Broockman and Malhotra, 2020; Ziaja, 2020), media organizations (Cagé et al., 2022; Glaeser, 2005), activist and pressure groups (Becker, 1983; Camous and Cooper, 2021; Mazumder, 2018), and migrant networks (Bazzi et al., 2025; Dippel and Heblich, 2021). This literature emphasizes the importance of political and economic conditions in determining where such resources are deployed, as well as their effects on subsequent political outcomes. I develop a framework in which electoral outcomes themselves help direct political investment. Insofar as winners are celebrated and mobilize while losers mourn and withdraw, even close electoral outcomes can generate persistent differences in political fortunes.

Finally, this paper offers a fresh perspective on the local mechanisms underlying the

partisan realignments of the twentieth century in the U.S. Previous work emphasizes the role of national shocks, including the New Deal, the Great Migration, and the civil rights movement, in shifting urban and minority voters toward the Democratic Party between 1940 and 1970 (Bazzi et al., 2023; Calderon et al., 2019; Kantor et al., 2013). These changes altered the geography of potential Democratic support, creating new opportunities for party investment. I show that elections themselves generated a feedback mechanism through which these opportunities became more salient to political actors: electoral victories revealed where Democratic investment could be profitable, and the resulting investment reinforced those initial gains. In other words, realignment was shaped not only by the national forces that changed the Democratic coalition, but also by a cumulative process in which electoral outcomes guided subsequent political investment.

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows. Section 2 develops the conceptual framework. Section 3 gives relevant historical background on U.S. politics and the Democratic Party in the mid-twentieth century. Section 4 establishes the RD strategy and main results. Sections 5 and 6 explore empirically the mechanisms underlying the main results. Section 7 examines the premium’s long-run implications, for both its persistence and the mid-century realignment. Section 8 concludes.

2 Conceptual Framework

Much of the political process is organized around winning elections. Indeed, winning is essential to gaining power and policy influence. Yet, winning confers something beyond those instrumental returns: the premium attached to the *winner* status itself. The source of this premium, I propose, lies in how political actors respond to the naming of a winner. Concretely, I consider two complementary mechanisms underlying the realization of the winner premium. The first is immediate in nature: the asymmetric affective response, or *behavioral salience*, to winning versus losing. The second is more gradual: in the months and years following an election, this asymmetry translates into differen-

tial *strategic investment* by winners and losers. Together—the first a spark, the second its amplification—these can render the salience of finishing first self-fulfilling, wherein claiming momentum after a win helps to mobilize the very resources that vindicate the expectation (Simon, 1954).

2.1 The Behavioral Salience of Winning and Losing

Consider two otherwise identical counties the morning after a presidential election: one narrowly carried by the Democratic candidate, the other narrowly lost. Besides that, the same candidate assumes national office either way, and no local position or policy turns on which way either county fell. Nevertheless, where the Democratic candidate prevailed, the result is received by the party as a victory to be celebrated; where they fell short, as a defeat to be mourned.¹ This asymmetry—what I term the *behavioral salience* of elections—is the first of the paper’s two proposed mechanisms: partisans, candidates, and activists respond to the binary fact of the outcome in ways that outstrip the information a razor-thin margin actually conveys.

Such asymmetric-response salience is well documented. Victories tend to raise satisfaction with the democratic process among winning candidates (Senninger et al., 2026) and voters (Singh et al., 2011), while losses bring demoralization and withdrawal (Pierce et al., 2016). Such effects are conspicuous even in close contests, where they cannot be reduced to the informational content of the result. This pattern is not peculiar to politics but reflects a general behavioral response to winning and losing in contests, with roots in neuroscience (Mehta and Josephs, 2006; Robertson, 2012; Zilioli and Watson, 2014). Outside of politics, Page and Coates (2017) document a performance boost from winning tie-breaks between men’s tennis professionals of similar rank; Lefgren et al. (2015) find that competitive basketball coaches revise lineup strategies after narrow losses that are all but uninformative about team quality; and at the national level, Depetris-Chauvin

¹For a recent example one can look to the 2016 presidential election, where the perennially Democratic county, Robeson, NC, narrowly voted Trump and the perennially Republican county, Cobb, GA, voted Clinton. Each defied the political narrative in its respective place, both at the time and since.

[et al. \(2020\)](#) show that sub-Saharan African countries whose football teams barely qualified for the Africa Cup of Nations experienced less subsequent civil conflict than those whose teams barely failed. Across these settings, the asymmetric response to a binary outcome appears largely independent of expertise, stakes, and the margin of victory, pointing to channels that are affective or heuristic rather than purely Bayesian.

If this mechanism is operative in the present setting, it carries a clear testable implication: a close win should leave an immediate and largely expressive imprint on how the outcome is received, well before any strategic response can form. Such an imprint would, for instance, surface in the contemporaneous local press, in the form of a discontinuous, asymmetric shift toward celebratory and away from mournful coverage of the winning party—one that arises within days of the result and is absent beforehand. Indeed, this is the pattern I test in [Section 5](#).

2.2 Strategic Investment and the Amplification of Rankings

A party's ability to convert a win into downstream mobilization depends on various political actors (e.g., party operatives, activists, donors) determining that local conditions favor their side and redirecting scarce resources accordingly. As such, it is through this second mechanism—which I call *strategic investment*—that initial affective asymmetries translate into a real winner premium.

Why even a *narrow* win should invite such differential investment, when it says little about underlying support, is not obvious. One rationalization involves a coordination logic: by provoking asymmetric responses among winners and losers, a publicly-observed electoral outcome constitutes a focal point for subsequent political investment. Hence, the mechanism operates not through the informational content of the result itself, but rather through beliefs about other actors' behavior. Recent work finds electoral rankings operating in just this way, with [Anagol and Fujiwara \(2016\)](#) and [Granzier et al. \(2023\)](#) showing that finishing ahead of a rival raises later success through the strate-

gic responses of candidates and voters, and [Testa and Williams \(2025\)](#) identifying elite mobilization keyed to the signal of even a narrow defeat.

Appendix [C](#) formalizes this logic as a coordination game, in which all agents observe a noisy public signal of local political fundamentals: their party's recent vote share margin. Whenever the vote share margin V is sufficiently positive (negative), fundamentals are strong (weak) with certainty and investing is always dominant (dominated) over withholding. But fix fundamentals at some intermediate level, where V is only slightly positive or negative, and neither action is dominant: investing is a best response only if alike actors also invest, which is *ex ante* unobservable.

Under standard global games arguments ([Carlsson and van Damme, 1993](#); [Morris and Shin, 1998, 2003](#)), introducing a small amount of idiosyncratic noise in the form of some private signal resolves the coordination problem, admitting a unique equilibrium in political investment. Insofar as private signals are correlated through place-specific unobservables, each political actor receiving a positive signal overall (i.e., given a slightly positive V) will place greater probability on alike actors also receiving a positive signal, thus further increasing the expected marginal benefit of political investment. As private signals become more reliable—for instance, where dense organizational networks repeat and amplify the result, leaving less to idiosyncratic local reads—each actor's own signal becomes a better guide to what others have seen, such that the equilibrium probability of investment takes on an S-shape, approaching a step function at $V = 0$. In the limit, the binary election outcome becomes a near-perfect coordinating device: political actors invest in places where their party recently won and withhold where it did not, even when the margin is small.

Together, this account carries two testable implications, which I take up in Section [6](#). First, if the redirection of investment is what carries the momentum from a win forward, its footprint should be concentrated where the organizational networks that direct political investment are indeed densest, e.g., where party chapters and aligned organizations operate. Second, strategic investment should operate through the concrete channels

available to parties and their allies: top-down, through voter registration advertising and direct outreach, and bottom-up, through selective in-migration and activism. A distinguishing feature of this mechanism is its timeline. Where the behavioral response of the previous subsection would play out over days, a strategic response should unfold over time—more muted in the immediate aftermath of a win, less so nearer the elections in which mobilization actually matters.

3 Historical Background

The empirical analysis focuses on a prolonged period of partisan realignment in U.S. presidential politics, which took place during the mid-twentieth century. This section provides some relevant historical background. First, I detail the major coalition changes that took place within the Democratic Party as the geography of winning evolved. I then describe the roles played by various political actors—party operatives, allied organizers, and activists—throughout this process.

The Changing Democratic Coalition. Over the twentieth century, the Democratic Party's coalition shifted from its historical Southern White base into densely-populated and minority-concentrated areas across the North and West. The process began after the 1936 election, when ward-level tallies and the Black press signaled a sharp swing toward President Franklin Roosevelt among Black voters. Thereafter, state parties, urban elites, and labor affiliates began to incorporate civil rights commitments into Democratic Party liberalism, with national leaders largely following rather than leading ([Schickler, 2016](#)).

This realignment did not occur all at once but instead gradually through the 1960s, with several factors contributing. First, changing demography made courting urban and Black voters more valuable over time. The Second Great Migration moved an additional four to five million Southern Black people into the industrial North and West between 1940 and 1970, enlarging Black electorates in important population centers ([Boustan, 2016](#)). These inflows increased Democratic vote shares, while also stimulating civil

rights activism in receiving counties, with these effects driven not only by migrants but also spillovers to progressive and working-class White voters ([Calderon et al., 2019](#)).

Second, shifts in national party platforms reinforced local coalition changes ([Bazzi et al., 2023](#)). In 1941, President Roosevelt bowed to pressure from civil rights activists and established the Fair Employment Practice Committee to investigate and eliminate racial discrimination in federal employment and defense industries. The Democrats doubled down on those efforts under President Harry Truman. In 1946, civil rights and organized labor groups, led by the Congress of Industrial Organizations (CIO), lobbied for potential legislation that would have made the FEPC permanent, while also expanding it across the private sector ([Farhang and Katznelson, 2005](#)). Despite Southern opposition, Truman advanced racial integration through executive action, notably by desegregating the armed forces in 1948 ([Katznelson, 2005](#)).

By the late 1940s, the potential for a successful political coalition cutting across urban, Black, and union lines was evident among organizers. Black journalists, such as Henry Lee Moon of the NAACP, popularized the idea of mobilizing Black voters to tip Northern states toward the Democratic Party ([Moon, 1948](#)). At the same time, CIO leaders worked in collaboration with civil rights groups to organize across racial lines in support of pro-union Democrats—an effort that extended, mostly unsuccessfully, to parts of the South through “Operation Dixie” ([Honey, 1992](#)).

Party Outreach and Investment, 1940–70. Democratic power brokers and aligned groups helped convert these structural opportunities into votes through coordinated outreach efforts. Organized labor built some of the earliest scalable operations. In 1943, the CIO created CIO-PAC to make endorsements, boost voter education, and promote get-out-the-vote drives. Following its 1955 merger, the AFL-CIO’s Committee on Political Education (COPE) expanded these efforts, using polling and member data to target spending and make direct-mail appeals across industrial states ([Dark, 1999](#); [Lichtenstein, 2002](#)).

Civil rights organizations supplied complementary infrastructure. At the local level, groups like the NAACP and the Congress of Racial Equality (CORE) organized county-by-county voter registration drives in both the South and in Northern areas where Black population shares were rising during the Great Migration, such as Detroit, Cleveland, and New York (Lawson, 1976; Valelly, 2004). CORE, founded in 1942 to advance nonviolent direct action, placed churches and neighborhood leaders at the center of their efforts, paralleling the methods used by party chapters and unions (Meier and Rudwick, 1973; Morris, 1984). At the national level, the NAACP's Washington Bureau worked to expand Black voter participation through sustained lobbying efforts on behalf of the Civil Rights Acts of 1957, 1960, and 1964 as well as the Voting Rights Act of 1965 (Watson, 1990).

By the 1960s, the combined efforts of labor, Black civic institutions, and local Democratic Party chapters had produced discernible gains in turnout. As Black migration continued and the national parties further diverged on civil rights throughout the decade, the Democratic Party systematically invested in urban areas—particularly in the North and West—emphasizing appeals that resonated with a broad base of Black and working-class White voters.

4 Empirical Evidence: The Winner Premium

Isolating the winner premium is difficult, insofar as winning comes bundled with the spoils of office. Indeed, one cannot simply compare the later fortunes of winning and losing candidates if the winner also subsequently holds office, with its incumbency and policy advantages. Instead, I study the *party's* performance in counties following *presidential* elections, where a win is of symbolic importance but delivers no local office or policy. Any subsequent rise in the party's local officeholding and voter support in turn reflects the premium associated with being *named* the winner, rather than the spoils of a particular office. I establish a causal interpretation of these effects before turning to

mechanisms in Sections 5 and 6.

4.1 Data and Variables

Prior to outlining the estimation strategy and results, I provide a short description of the primary data and their sources. For summary statistics of all primary and secondary variables, see Appendix Table A.1.

Primary Variables. The primary outcome variables are measures of the change in Democratic local officeholders and presidential voters between election periods, relative to the opposition party, covering the 1940–72 period. For the former, I rely on information on the number and partisan composition of public local officeholders (e.g., mayors, council members) matched to counties at a given point in time from the Political Graveyard (Kestenbaum, 2023).² For the latter, I use county-level vote tabulations for presidential elections from Clubb et al. (2006), which is also the source used to construct the primary explanatory variable.

For secondary outcomes, I use data from the American National Election Studies (2021) for individual-level response data; data from newspapers.com to derive measures of electoral response salience and political advertisements in newspapers; data from the 1% or 5% (where available) samples of the 1950–70 U.S. Censuses from Schroeder et al. (2025); and data on Congress of Racial Equality (CORE) activity from Gregory and Hermida (2025).

Secondary Variables. Most county-level observables, such as population density, Black population shares, and labor force participation, are sourced directly from the aggregate U.S. Censuses (Haines, 2010). Data on Black church membership, including the National Baptist Church, the African Methodist Episcopal, and the Church of God in

²Concretely, I first define for each individual in the database their first and last years in office, by office. I then code a given individual as a public local officeholder for all years identified as such for local offices only. After that, I sum the number of public officials linked to a given county as of the beginning of a given four-year election period, both overall and by party. See Appendix A.2 for a fuller description. For the main analysis, I calculate the differences in these values across presidential election years.

Christ, come from [U.S. Bureau of the Census \(1940\)](#) via [Haines \(2010\)](#). Data on racial dissimilarity across neighborhoods in counties as of 1940 come from [Logan and Parman \(2017\)](#). Data on NAACP chapters and CIO union chapters come from [Estrada and Gregory \(2025\)](#) and [Gregory and Molyneux \(2025\)](#), respectively.

4.2 Identification Strategy

This section explores whether counties where the Democrat narrowly won the popular vote in presidential elections between 1940 and 1968 saw improvements in the party’s relative performance subsequently—that is, conferred a *winner premium* over the runner-up—using a regression discontinuity (RD) design. The key identifying assumption is that counties where the Democratic candidate for president *barely* won are similar in all other ways to those where he barely lost (see [Lee et al., 2004](#); [Ferreira and Gyourko, 2009](#)).

The primary estimating equation is the following:

$$\Delta Dem. Perform_{c(s),\tau+1} = \beta \cdot Dem. Won_{c,\tau} + f(V_{c,\tau}) + \phi_\tau + \theta_s + \mathbf{X}'_{c,\tau} \mathbf{\Gamma} + \varepsilon_{c,\tau}. \quad (1)$$

For the baseline analysis, I define:

$$\Delta Dem. Perform_{c(s),\tau+1} = (Dem_{c,\tau+1} - Opp_{c,\tau+1}) - (Dem_{c,\tau} - Opp_{c,\tau})$$

as the change in the Democratic Party’s relative performance (i.e., plurality) in the number of (i) local *officeholders* or (ii) presidential *voters* in a given county between elections τ and $\tau + 1$, relative to the Democrats’ primary opposition party in c as of τ ,³ where τ indicates the presidential election held in November of $\tau = \{1940, 1944, \dots, 1968\}$. Secondary analyses consider absolute changes. In the baseline specification, I control for

³In other words, if the Democrats won in presidential election τ , then the primary opposition party is whichever nominated the top runner-up candidate in c at τ . If the Democrats lost in τ , then this is the winning party in c .

the total number of local officeholders or presidential voters in a given county as of τ , respectively.⁴

β captures the winner premium, where the primary regressor, *Dem. Won_{c τ}* , equals one if the Democratic candidate for president won the popular vote in county c in a given election τ . The elections of 1940 through 1968 were characterized by historically high levels of partisan competition—bounded by the landslide elections of 1936 and 1972.⁵ As Section 3 describes, this coincided with a gradual shift in partisan allegiances across the country, with the Democratic Party increasingly winning in urban and minority areas as it lost its grip on the South (see Figure 1 for net shifts in Democratic Party support over this period across the 48 conterminous U.S. states). This period is thus particularly well-suited to serve as an historical testing ground for the conceptual framework in Section 2.

Leveraging this local political competition, I identify causal effects using an RD design. By interacting *Dem. Won_{c τ}* with a running variable for the Democratic vote share margin, $f(V_{c\tau})$, I estimate treatment effects based on counties with close vote shares in a given election. Under the testable assumption that close elections tend to occur in otherwise similar places, this strategy provides quasi-random treatment variation. I adopt a linear running polynomial for the main analysis, while reporting estimates based on other polynomial choices as robustness. I also follow Calonico et al. (2014) and adopt data-driven mean squared error (MSE) optimal bandwidth choices with a triangular kernel, thus prioritizing observations relatively close to the RD threshold where $V_{c\tau} = 0$. As illustration, Figure 2 shows the spatial distribution of *highly* marginal cases, based on counties with more than one win or loss within a 5 percentage points (p.p.) bandwidth of the threshold.

Isolating the “Status” Effects of Winning. My empirical strategy aims to sepa-

⁴I do not scale outcomes by total officeholders or voters, given the presence of small- or zero-valued observations, particularly for officeholders. I nevertheless show robustness to using share-based measures.

⁵See Appendix Figure A.1 and Appendix Table A.2 for further historical context for this claim.

rate the premium of being *named* the winner from the spoils that winning also brings. Presidential elections are well-suited to this end: unlike congressional or local elections, a presidential win has no direct impact on local officeholding or policy. At the same time, political actors pay close attention to county-level vote shares, to the extent that they reveal shifting political trends and crucial swing areas (see Section 2). As such, any downstream effect is likely to work solely through the *status* of the win. To bolster this argument, I later provide evidence that (close) election results are not systematically correlated across the local and national levels, which might otherwise generate incumbency-like effects through local officeholding channels.

Threats to Identification. The empirical strategy in (1) faces two main challenges. The first concerns the standard assumption that relevant factors besides the outcome be continuous around the RD threshold, $V_{c\tau} = 0$. If not satisfied, estimates may reflect discontinuities in factors besides the treatment variable. To test this, I first examine the density of the running variable around this threshold. Insofar as electoral outcomes were manipulable (e.g., in Southern states with “Jim Crow” laws), such selection could generate differences between treatment and control counties. Using the formal test from Cattaneo et al. (2018) following McCrary (2008), I fail at conventional levels ($p = 0.55$) to reject the null hypothesis that $V_{c\tau}$ is continuous at the RD threshold (see Figure 3). I later show robustness to dropping Southern states entirely. As a further test, I estimate discontinuities among a wide set of relevant pre-treatment factors in place of the outcome in equation (1). I fail to estimate statistically significant differences at the RD threshold across all factors, as shown in Table 1, with robustness in Appendix Table B.1. I later show further robustness to including these factors as flexible controls in the main RD analysis.

The second challenge concerns the potential for relevant unobservables to be correlated in nearby space within or across time periods. I deal with such concerns in two main ways. First, I feature in the baseline specification a set of *spatial controls*, which

includes both state fixed effects (θ_s) and quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude ($\mathbf{X}_{c\tau}$). Together, these account for relevant factors in space not fully captured by the unidimensional running variable.⁶ I also show robustness to more demanding control sets. I furthermore allow for local serial correlation in unobservables by clustering standard errors at the county level. For the purpose of defining clusters, counties are assumed to become different administrative units if their boundaries change across election periods, even if their formal identifiers remain unchanged in the data.⁷ I later show robustness to the unit of clustering.

4.3 Main Results: Election Results and Local Democratic Gains

I now report the main empirical findings, which reveal a winner premium in local political support: (close) Democratic presidential wins are followed by relative increases in Democratic local officeholding and voter support over the subsequent four-year election period. I begin by establishing baseline estimates for both outcomes, using the RD strategy outlined above.

Main Results. Table 2 reports estimates of β in equation (1). Panel (a) shows that counties narrowly won by the Democratic Party in presidential elections τ from 1940 to 1968 saw sharp increases through $\tau + 1$ in the number of Democratic local officeholders (e.g., mayors, clerks), relative to the primary opposition party in τ (columns 1–2). The preferred estimate in column 1 implies .055 additional Democratic officeholders relative to the opposition for every close Democratic win—consistent with about 9.6 additional Democratic officeholders on net per every 100 offices. This estimate is based on a linear running polynomial, plus baseline covariates of year FE, state FE, quadratic polynomials

⁶Longitude and latitude are often used as running variables in spatial RD designs (Cattaneo and Titiunik, 2022).

⁷Nearly 1 out of every 8 counties included in the overall sample experiences at least one boundary change over the sample period. Despite this, the RD strategy precludes the harmonization of county boundaries to a common year, as it is essential that vote margins correspond to their ground-truth values. Boundary changes likewise complicate the use of county fixed effects, although I later show robustness to their inclusion nevertheless.

in county longitude and latitude, and the total number of local officeholders linked to a given county as of the beginning of τ . Columns 3–4 estimate this gain in absolute terms, while columns 5–6 find little change in the *total* number of local offices—that is, the premium redistributes offices toward the winning party rather than expanding the officeholding pie.

Panel (b) shows that counties narrowly won by the Democratic Party in presidential elections likewise saw large increases in the number of Democratic presidential voters across elections relative to the opposition. The preferred estimate in column 1 implies about 2,100 additional Democratic voters over the opposition for every close Democratic win, or about 9.1 additional Democratic votes on net per every 100 votes. As with officeholders, this widening lead reflects gains in Democratic votes (columns 3–4) rather than larger increases in the overall size of the electorate (columns 5–6).

Note that these estimates constitute local average treatment effects (LATE) and are based on MSE-optimal bandwidths, which limit the set of observations to those near the Democratic win-lose threshold, for which local randomization is plausibly satisfied. In other words, while the full sample contains around 24,500 county-election observations, the main treatment effects are estimated from less than half that, with the exact number of observations varying by outcome and specification.

I complement these tabular results with visual RD plots in Figure 4, which show the same discontinuities as in the tabular results.

Robustness Checks. To bolster a causal interpretation for the core results in Table 2, I now present a suite of additional robustness checks.

Inference. Panel (a) of Table 3 shows that results are robust to using alternative inference procedures, which guard against biases resulting from correlated unobservables across counties with similar fundamentals. These include clustering standard errors at the state level, which slightly increases precision, and clustering at the state-year level, which slightly decreases it.

Varying Controls. Panel (b) of Table 3 considers alternate sets of covariates in equation (1). Estimates remain large and significant at conventional levels in more conservative specifications that omit all covariates besides the running variable (row 2), all spatial covariates (row 3), or the longitude and latitude polynomials (row 4).

Results are likewise robust to including further covariates, such as state-by-year FE (row 5). Row 6 further verifies the assumptions underpinning the RD, flexibly controlling for all variables from Table 1. Finally, as an alternative to state fixed effects, row 7 uses county fixed effects, which are based on the fixed-boundary identifiers at which standard errors are clustered in the baseline specification.

Alternative RD Specifications. I test sensitivity to alternative bandwidths and running polynomials in panel (c) of Table 3. Row 8 fixes the bandwidth of each outcome to 25 p.p. from the RD threshold, while rows 9 and 10 re-estimate the specification in row 1 with the optimal bandwidths multiplied by factors of 0.5 and 1.5, respectively. Rows 11 and 12 vary the running polynomial itself, with estimates based on hyper-flexible cubic and quartic forms. Results remain substantively intact in all cases and significant at conventional levels.

Sample Sensitivity. The analysis includes the counties of all conterminous “lower 48” U.S. states across presidential elections between 1940 and 1968. Indeed, the Democratic Party was competitive across the country throughout that period. Nevertheless, I explore sensitivity to these choices.

First, row 13 in panel (d) of Table 3 considers only counties in non-Southern states, where the Democratic Party tended to be gaining, while row 14 considers those counties within the South, where it faced little competition through the 1950s before steadily losing ground.⁸ Whereas the former estimates are large relative to the baseline results, the latter are smaller and less precise.

More granularly, Appendix Figure B.1 shows that the results are not particularly

⁸This is based on the Southern U.S. Census region, which includes the 11 former Confederate states, Delaware, Kentucky, Maryland, Oklahoma, and West Virginia.

sensitive to omitting any individual sample state or election period. Holding all other aspects of the specification fixed, I drop in panel (a) each of the 48 sample states one-by-one from the sample. No particular state appears to drive the main effect. Panel (b) then explores sensitivity to dropping individual elections. Across the two outcomes, no particular period appears to systematically drive effects, which retain a positive sign throughout.

Lastly, rows 15 and 16 of panel (d) of Table 3 address the competitive third-party candidacies present in some elections (e.g., 1948, 1968). Row 15 considers only counties in which the Republican Party was the primary opposition to the Democrats, while row 16 restricts to county-elections in which the top two candidates together captured over 95% of the vote. Estimates remain positive and significant under either restriction.

Alternative Outcome Measurement. I consider an array of alternative outcome measures in Appendix Table B.2. These include (i) the share of Democratic local officeholders (presidential voters) in election $\tau + 1$; (ii) the percentage point change in the share of Democratic local officeholders (presidential voters) between τ and $\tau + 1$; and (iii) the percentage point change in the relative share of Democratic local officeholders (presidential voters) over the primary opposition between τ and $\tau + 1$. All three variants result in substantively similar measures to the baseline estimates, with estimates for local officeholders tending to be somewhat imprecise due to sample size reductions from zero-valued denominators.

Time-Varying Confounders and Pre-Treatment Effects. To what extent do the results reflect partisan changes that were ongoing prior to or concurrent with the treatment? I consider the potential for time-varying confounders in three ways.

First, I vary the timing of the outcome measure to examine the possibility of relevant pre-treatment trends. Indeed, one concern is that a county experiencing a (close) Democratic win in τ may have been swinging in the direction of Democrats already, thus confounding the treatment effect. Table 4 examines both relative and absolute changes

in Democratic local officeholding (presidential voting) across pre-treatment windows (i) $\tau - 1$ to τ , (ii) $\tau - 2$ to $\tau - 1$, and (iii) $\tau - 2$ to τ . All such estimates are small and imprecise, consistent with treatment assignment in τ being uncorrelated with pre-treatment trends.

Second, Appendix Table B.3 considers whether treatment effects may be differentially driven by the subset of counties that did have pre-treatment trends. For both outcomes, there is no difference in treatment effects across counties trending toward versus away from Democrats in the periods preceding the treatment.

Third, Appendix Table B.4 considers the possibility of local officeholder gains contemporaneous with a close presidential win in τ (i.e., if election results are systematically correlated across the local and national levels). If these exist, they could generate incumbency-like effects through local officeholding channels. Ultimately, I find no evidence that Democrats were more likely to be elected to local office over the primary opposition in counties where the Democratic candidate for president barely won the popular vote.

Placebo Cutoffs. Lastly, I test for false positives in the treatment effects using a permutation test that estimates the baseline RD specification at 1,000 placebo cutoffs, holding all other aspects of the specification fixed. Following Ganong and Jager (2018), the share of placebo estimates exceeding the true estimate implies a randomization inference p -value. If the effect estimated at the actual threshold of $V_{c\tau} = 0$ simply reflects one of many nonlinearities in the relationship between the outcome and the assignment variable, this p -value should be large, suggesting a spurious treatment effect. Appendix Figure B.2 shows the range of t-statistics and point estimates from alternative thresholds $V_{c\tau} + \rho$, with ρ from -25 to 25 p.p. The implied randomization inference p -value—the share of placebo t-statistics exceeding the true one—is 0.004 for the officeholder outcome and 0.003 for the voter outcome.

4.4 Micro Effects: Election Results and Democratic Identification

Turning to the micro level, I examine shifts in party identification and registration among individuals living in counties where Democrats won the presidential vote. For this, I rely on the American National Election Studies (ANES) survey, which began associating respondents with a county of residence in 1956. Thus, I examine a pooled sample of ANES respondents spanning all four-year election periods from 1952 to 1968.

Table 5 reports estimates of β in equation (1), with an indicator for Democratic Party identification (columns 1–3) and Democratic Party registration (columns 4–6) as individual-level outcomes. For the latter, I consider an individual to be a registered Democrat if they are both registered to vote and identify as Democratic. Estimates are based on a version of the main specification, using a linear running polynomial together with baseline covariates and individual dummies for White, male, and age FE. I estimate these effects both overall and within racial groups.

I find positive and significant increases in Democratic identification and registration in the pooled-race sample, of about 4 p.p. (i.e., 5% over the mean) and 11 p.p. (23%) respectively. Note that the registration effects are somewhat larger than the identification effects, both in absolute terms and relative to the outcome means. When estimation is done by race, I find similar effects among Black respondents for identification and registration, consistent with a 27 p.p. increase in each outcome, or about 39–43% over the mean. For White respondents, estimates remain positive but are smaller and less precise, with effects on Democratic identification and registration of 3.5 p.p. (i.e., 4% over the mean) and 10 p.p. (21%), respectively.

Together with the results in Table 2, these findings suggest that when Democrats won the popular vote in presidential contests over the sample period—however narrow the margin—local political support for Democratic Party candidates in local and national contests increased sharply thereafter. I now turn to the mechanisms underlying this effect.

5 Behavioral Salience: Winners Celebrate, Losers Mourn

Why did the Democratic Party’s performance improve in counties where its presidential candidate won the popular vote—even barely? This section turns to the sources of this winner premium. Guided by the conceptual framework in Section 2, I focus first on the *behavioral salience* of electoral outcomes. Under such a mechanism, even narrow wins and losses should provoke differential affective reactions in the period immediately following the election.

To test this, I examine sentiment in election coverage among counties’ local newspapers over time. Independent of which party actually won the presidential election nationally, coverage of the county-level popular vote winner should turn more celebratory and less mournful relative to that of its primary opposition, resulting in a discontinuous, asymmetric shift at the RD threshold, $V_{c\tau} = 0$ immediately after a given election (but not before).

Using full-text newspaper page images from newspapers.com, I count, for each election from 1940 to 1968, the pages that pair a celebratory phrase (e.g., “won,” “victory”) or a mournful one (e.g., “loss,” “lose”) with a party or its presidential nominee, and construct an *asymmetric-response salience index* (ARSI): celebratory-minus-mournful references to the Democratic side, net of the same for the county’s primary opposition, for each county and day around the election (see Appendix A.4).

Figure 5 shows the discontinuity in this index at the RD threshold, day by day around the election. In the run-up to the result, the gap between narrowly-winning and narrowly-losing counties is flat and indistinguishable from zero; a joint test does not reject that the pre-election estimates are all zero ($p = 0.64$). It then jumps sharply once the county-level popular vote is known, peaking within two days—the local press in barely-won counties turning markedly more celebratory and less mournful toward the Democratic side than in barely-lost counties—before fading over the following two weeks. Note that this response is immediate and short-lived, playing out over days rather than the years

across which the strategic channel of Section 6 operates.

Appendix Figure A.2 decomposes the index into its two sides, which both move as the mechanism predicts. In barely-won counties, celebratory-minus-mournful coverage of the Democratic side rises (panel a), while the same measure for the opposition falls by a comparable amount (panel b). That this shift is discontinuous at a margin of essentially zero, mirrored across the two sides, and confined to the days around the result is all consistent with an affective response to the binary fact of winning or losing—as opposed to the negligible informational content that such a razor-thin margin conveys. Together, these results show that winners celebrate while losers mourn. Yet, does this response serve as a spark for downstream political investment? Section 6 turns to the slower, strategic response that converts it into a durable premium.

6 Strategic Investment: Top-down and Bottom-up

Section 5 traced the immediate, expressive response to a close win. Yet, that alone need not leave a durable mark. For that, the framework in Section 2 points to a second, slower mechanism—*strategic investment*—whereby party operatives, allied organizations, and activists redirect scarce resources toward places their side recently won. This account carries two testable implications, which now organize this section. First, the premium should be concentrated where the organizational networks that direct such investment are densest—the urban, Black, and labor strongholds that anchored the mid-century Democratic coalition (Section 6.1). Second, the investment should surface in the concrete channels open to parties and their allies. Section 6.2 focuses on voter registration advertising as a general, “top-down” channel. Section 6.3 then turns to the racial dimension that defined the era’s realignment, where investment ran both top-down, through outreach and mobilization, and “bottom-up,” through activism and selective migration.

6.1 The Geography of Political Investment

Political investment is deployed through various organizational infrastructures, with party chapters, civic groups, and unions directing resources in different places. For the mid-twentieth century Democratic coalition, this infrastructure was concentrated in the urban, Black, and labor strongholds outside the South (see Section 3). If the winner premium runs through such investment, it should be largest precisely there.

Table 6 tests this by splitting the baseline RD sample on measures of pre-treatment organizational presence: whether a county had (i) any incumbent Democratic officeholders in τ , (ii) high population density in 1940, (iii) any NAACP chapters in 1940, (iv) high Black church membership, and (v) any CIO union chapters in 1940. The pattern is stark and consistent across these dimensions. In counties with each indicator of infrastructure, the premium is several times its baseline size—for example, the effect on the Democratic officeholding lead is roughly six times larger in counties with an NAACP presence (column 5) than in the pooled sample—while in counties without it, the estimates fall to essentially zero (even-numbered columns). The premium thus materialized precisely in the urban, Black, and union areas where the Democratic coalition was organizing, and scarcely at all elsewhere.

6.2 Advertising and Voter Registration

The most direct top-down channel is party-organized voter registration. I measure this using registration advertising in local newspapers, again based on articles from [newspapers.com](#). For each party I search a set of phrases aimed at recruiting new voters (e.g., “register as a democrat,” “change from republican to democrat”), geolocate the matching pages to counties, and take the net Democratic count—Democratic minus Republican registration-ad pages—by county and year (see Appendix A.5).

Table 7 shows that a close Democratic win raises net Democratic registration advertising over the ensuing cycle (column 5), with the Democratic count alone rising about

18% relative to its mean (column 7). The shape of the effect is quite telling. Muted in first and third years after the election, it doubles in size during the second year—the year of the midterm elections—and is largest in the fourth—the year of the next presidential contest (columns 1–4). This is precisely the timing one would expect for a strategic response that builds toward the elections in which voter mobilization matters. Crucially, it is only a response to the win itself; the same advertising shows no discontinuity in the prior election cycle (columns 6 and 8).

6.3 Racial Politics: Persuasion and Selection

The political investment of the sample period concentrated especially along one cleavage—race—which perhaps did more than any other to define the realignment (Schickler, 2016). As Section 3 describes, the Second Great Migration enlarged the Black electorate across the industrial North and West through the 1970s, and it was there that the Democratic coalition invested most heavily in its emerging Black constituency. I find evidence of such investment on both sides: from the top down, *persuasion* of these counties through the party’s outreach and its allies’ organizing; and from the bottom up, the *selection* of Black migrants toward the places the party had recently carried.

On the persuasion side, the investment ran both top-down and through allied grass-roots networks. First, party affiliates stepped up direct outreach. In the ANES, Democratic contact rose sharply among Black—but not White—respondents in counties following a close Democratic win (columns 1–2 of Table 8). Civil rights organizing moved in parallel: counties the Democrats most recently carried were about twice as likely to see Congress of Racial Equality (CORE) activity (e.g., sit-ins, marches) in the four years that followed (columns 1–2 of Table 9). The imprint reached attitudes as well as actions, with approval of protest, civil disobedience, and demonstrations rising markedly among residents of recent-win counties (columns 3–8 of Table 9).

Selection reinforced persuasion. Drawing on pooled Census samples of interstate

movers,⁹ I find that a migrant into a county the Democrats had recently (barely) won was about 34% more likely to be Black (column 3 of Table 8), with the effect concentrated in destinations that already had an NAACP presence (columns 4–5) and dense Black church membership (columns 6–7). Recent election rankings thus appear to have coordinated political investment in space along racial lines, drawing party and civil rights resources—and Black migrants themselves—toward the counties where the Democratic coalition was gaining ground.

7 Long-Run Implications: Persistence and Realignment

Having established the winner premium and the channels through which it operates, I turn to its longer-run consequences for the Democratic Party’s trajectory. Two questions organize this section. First, does the premium *endure* beyond the election that produces it? Second, was it *large enough*—aggregated across a competitive map—to have shaped the party’s national fortunes, and with them the mid-century realignment? The first is a question about the persistence of a causal effect; the second, a more illustrative accounting of its cumulative electoral weight.

7.1 Does the Winner Premium Persist?

The effects of political investment in a given place have the potential to persist over the longer term, while beliefs formed about the benefits of investing in a given place may likewise prove sticky, favoring long-term investment.

To examine these longer-run effects, I assign event-time dummies to counties based on their *first* Democratic win. I then estimate the dynamic effects of those wins on the Democratic Party’s number of (i) local officeholders and (ii) presidential voters within

⁹The sample pools individual household heads aged 18 or older from the 1% or 5% U.S. Census samples who moved across states between the 1940, 1944, or 1948 elections and the 1950 Census; the 1952 election and the 1960 Census; or the 1960 or 1964 elections and the 1970 Census. The 1960 and 1970 Censuses asked about location five years prior, precluding 1956–60 and 1968–70 movers.

counties (based on fixed-boundary county units), relative to the party’s primary opposition in the first-win presidential election $\tau \in \{1940, \dots, 1968\}$. To estimate effects based specifically on *close* Democratic wins, I limit observations to those with a Democratic vote share margin $V_{c\tau} \in [0, 25]$, with all event dummies interacted with $V_{c\tau}$. Estimation follows the usual triangular kernel, with observations weighted inversely by a county’s absolute Democratic vote share margin relative to the primary opposition in τ . As robustness, I also present a range of estimates from different windows of first-closeness in $V_{c\tau}$.¹⁰

Dynamic estimates, shown as an event study in Figure 6, reveal increases in the relative number of Democratic local officeholders (panel a) and presidential voters (panel b) following a county’s first close Democratic win, which persist over time—for at least three election periods at conventional levels of statistical significance. Appendix Table B.5 presents the corresponding difference-in-difference estimates among ever-treated counties for a range of closeness windows, of which all are positive in sign. Overall, this suggests that close Democratic wins may have facilitated long-lived coordination of political investment in space, helping to drive more persistent shifts in local party constituencies and coalitions.

7.2 An Illustrative Counterfactual: The Premium and Realignment

An alternative way of assessing the long-term impact of the winner premium is to consider its role in tipping individual elections of historical partisan importance. Because

¹⁰Overall, the estimating strategy here is

$$Dem. Perform_{c(s),t} = \sum_{k \neq 0} \beta_k \mathbb{I}\{t - \tau = k\} \times V_{c,\tau} + \phi_t + \theta_c + \varepsilon_{c,t},$$

where τ here denotes the event year of county c ’s first close Democratic presidential win; $Dem. Perform_{c(s),t}$ gives the size of Democratic Party’s plurality in local officeholders or presidential voters over the primary opposition in c and election period t ; and $\mathbb{I}\{t - \tau = k\}$ is a dummy equal to 1 if an observation is k periods before or after the first close win, with omitted $k = 0$ corresponding to $t = \tau$. All event dummies are separately interacted with the Democratic margin $V_{c\tau}$. Following equation (1), estimation follows a triangular kernel, weighted inversely by a county’s absolute Democratic vote share margin relative to the primary opposition in τ ; ϕ_t gives election year FE; and θ_c gives (boundary-specific) county FE; with $\varepsilon_{c,t}$ clustered at the (boundary-specific) county level.

presidential elections are decided state by state, even a modest per-county advantage can prove decisive in states where contests are close. If enough states are close, the premium—even confined to a single electoral cycle—has the potential to be nationally consequential, with one flipped election potentially influencing the downstream calculus of party strategists.

This invites a rough accounting of the winner premium’s footprint on the mid-century realignment. I take the baseline estimate at face value: each close Democratic win added about 2,118 net Democratic presidential votes over the opposition—some 9.1 per 100 cast—in the following election (column 1 of panel (b) in Table 2). Crediting this premium to every county that won narrowly, I remove it from that county’s Democratic lead, re-aggregate to state totals, and check whether each state’s Democratic plurality survives.¹¹ I report two accountings in Appendix Table B.6: an *additive* version that credits each close winner the same 2,118 votes, and a *proportional* version that credits 9.1 percent of the county’s own turnout, up-weighting high-turnout places in a manner analogous to weighting counties by their electoral significance.

Under both, the winner premium proves to be decisive in precisely *two* closely-contested elections that the Democrats won: 1948 and 1960. Under the additive accounting the opposition secures an outright majority (85 and 57 electoral votes flip, respectively), and under the proportional accounting *no* candidate reaches one (60 and 47 electoral votes flip). In the other elections—though all still relatively competitive at the county level—the premium never flips enough individual states to affect the national outcome. Note that the two versions do differ somewhat in terms of where the premium is pivotal. The additive accounting, by subtracting the same premium from all close-

¹¹Concretely, for each election $\tau + 1 \in \{1944, \dots, 1972\}$, I credit every county that won narrowly in τ (within the MSE-optimal bandwidth of column 1) with the estimated premium, subtract it from that county’s Democratic-minus-opposition presidential vote lead, sum to state totals, and record a state as pivotal if its Democratic plurality is positive but would turn negative once the premium is removed; electoral votes follow the apportionment in force at each election. The exercise is best read as an upper bound: it applies a local average treatment effect estimated near the win-loss threshold to all counties winning within the bandwidth, thereby over-crediting less competitive counties; it treats each county’s contribution as additive and abstracts from any offsetting response by the opposition; and it ignores cross-county spillovers, which would if anything amplify the aggregate.

win counties regardless of population, is more likely to flip relatively rural states; the proportional accounting, by scaling the premium to local turnout, shifts the pivotal map toward the urban North. At the same time, the accountings overlap on key states, such as California, Iowa, and Ohio in 1948, and Missouri and New Mexico in 1960.

Yet, that the two contests the premium rescues elected Truman and Kennedy—presidents whose progressivism on civil rights helped steer the party’s subsequent course—is telling. By keeping those wins in the Democratic column, the premium plausibly nudged the party’s longer-run direction. Of course, these exercises are illustrative and hinge on very strong all-else-equal assumptions. Yet, the broader point stands: the same force that leads a narrow winner to win more, compounded over a competitive map and across two decades, can help to redraw that map itself. Viewed this way, the winner premium can be seen as an important engine of realignment—a channel through which the near-arbitrary outcomes of close elections, by steering where parties subsequently invest, accumulate into durable shifts in the geography of American political power.

8 Conclusion

The twentieth century brought about a massive realignment in American politics. At the beginning of the century, the Democratic Party dominated among White and agrarian interests across the country’s South and rural core. Yet, a series of national shocks shuffled political coalitions across the country’s major parties, with the progressive movement, the New Deal, the Great Migration, and the civil rights movement increasingly expanding the Democrats’ working-class base into Northern cities and minority areas ([Bazzi et al., 2023](#); [Calderon et al., 2019](#); [Kantor et al., 2013](#); [Kuziemko and Washington, 2018](#); [Schickler, 2016](#)).

This paper shows how elections themselves guided and reinforced this process, by directing attention and resources toward places based on which party won the popular vote in presidential elections. For the Democratic Party, the resulting gains were

concentrated most in urban, Black, and union areas, where dense networks of organizations and activists helped anchor party investment. Together, these results underscore an important yet little-understood value-added of competitive elections in making modern democracies function: more than just reveal political support, they also help to direct it.

References

- American National Election Studies**, “ANES 2020 Time Series Study Full Release,” 2021. [dataset and documentation], July 19, 2021 version.
- Anagol, S. and T. Fujiwara**, “The Runner-up Effect,” *Journal of Political Economy*, 2016, 124 (4), 927–91.
- Baskaran, T. and Z. Hessami**, “Does the Election of a Female Leader Clear the Way for More Women in Politics?,” *American Economy Journal: Economic Policy*, 2018, 10 (3), 95–121.
- Bazzi, S., A. Ferrara, M. Fiszbein, T. Pearson, and P. A. Testa**, “The Other Great Migration: Southern Whites and the New Right,” *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 2023, 138, 1577–1647.
- , —, —, —, —, and —, “The Confederate Diaspora,” *Review of Economic Studies*, 2025.
- Becker, G. S.**, “A Theory of Competition Among Pressure Groups for Political Influence,” *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 1983, 98 (3), 371–400.
- Benedictis-Kessner, J. De**, “Off-Cycle and Out of Office: Election Timing and the Incumbency Advantage,” *Journal of Politics*, 2018, 80 (1).
- Bochenkova, A., P. Buonanno, and S. Galletta**, “Fighting Violence Against Women: The Role of Female Political Representation,” *Journal of Development Economics*, 2023, *Forthcoming*.
- Boustan, L. P.**, *Competition in the Promised Land: Black Migrants in Northern Cities and Labor Markets*, Princeton University Press, Princeton, NJ, 2016.
- Broockman, D. and N. Malhotra**, “What Do Partisan Donors Want?,” *Public Opinion Quarterly*, 2020, 84 (1), 104–118.
- Cagé, J., N. Hervé, and M. Viaud**, “How the Ultrarich Use Media Ownership as a Political Investment,” *The Journal of Politics*, 2022, 84 (4), 1885–2311.
- Calderon, A., V. Fouka, and M. Tabellini**, “Racial Diversity, Electoral Preferences, and the Supply of Policy: The Great Migration and Civil Rights,” *Harvard Business School BGIE Unit Working Paper*, 2019, (20-017).
- Calonico, S., M. D. Cattaneo, and R. Titiunik**, “Robust nonparametric confidence intervals for regression-discontinuity designs,” *Econometrica*, 2014, 82, 2295–326.
- Camous, A. and R. Cooper**, “Political Activism and the Provision of Dynamic Incentives: Growing the Pie in the Battle for Redistribution,” *The Economic Journal*, 2021, 131 (639), 2824–2855.
- Carlsson, H. and E. van Damme**, “Global Games and Equilibrium Selection,” *Econometrica*, 1993, 61, 989–1018.
- Cattaneo, M. D. and R. Titiunik**, “Regression Discontinuity Designs,” *Annual Review of Economics*, 2022, 14, 821–51.
- , **M. Jansson, and X. Ma**, “Manipulation Testing Based on Density Discontinuity,” *Stata Journal*, 2018, 18, 234–61.

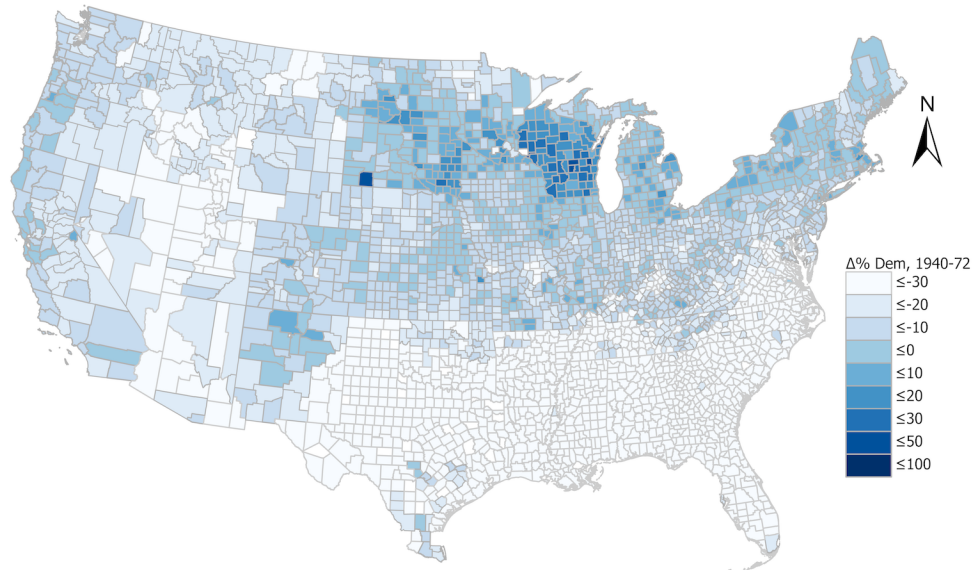
- Clubb, J. M., W. H. Flanigan, and N. H. Zingale**, “Electoral Data for Counties in the United States: Presidential and Congressional Races, 1840-1972,” *Inter-university Consortium for Political and Social Research [distributor]*, Ann Arbor, MI, 2006-11-13. <https://doi.org/10.3886/ICPSR08611.v1>, 2006.
- Dark, T. E.**, *The Unions and the Democrats: An Enduring Alliance*, Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, ILR Press, 1999.
- Depetris-Chauvin, E., R. Durante, and F. Campante**, “Building Nations through Shared Experiences: Evidence from African Football,” *American Economic Review*, 2020, 110 (5), 1572–1602.
- Dippel, C. and S. Heblich**, “Leadership in Social Movements: Evidence from the “Forty-Eighters” in the Civil War,” *American Economic Review*, February 2021, 111 (2), 472–505.
- Eggers, A. C. and A. Spirling**, “Incumbency Effects and the Strength of Party Preferences: Evidence from Multiparty Elections in the United Kingdom,” *Journal of Politics*, 2017, 79 (3).
- Egorov, G. and K. Sonin**, “Elections in Non-Democracies,” *The Economic Journal*, 2021, 131 (636), 1682–1716.
- Estrada, Josue and James Gregory**, “Mapping NAACP Chapters 1912–1977,” Mapping American Social Movements Project, University of Washington 2025. Last accessed October 13, 2025.
- Farhang, S. and I. Katznelson**, “The Southern Imposition: Congress and Labor in the New Deal Order,” *Studies in American Political Development*, 2005, 19 (1), 1–30.
- Ferreira, F. V. and J. Gyourko**, “Do Political Parties Matter? Evidence from U.S. Cities,” *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 2009, 124.
- and —, “Does gender matter for political leadership? The case of U.S. mayors,” *Journal of Public Economics*, 2014, 112.
- Ganong, S. and P. Jager**, “A Permutation Test for the Regression Kink Design,” *Journal of the American Statistical Association*, 2018, 113 (522), 494–504.
- Gimpel, J. G., A. Reeves, and S. Trende**, “Reconsidering Bellwether Locations in U.S. Presidential Elections,” *Presidential Studies Quarterly*, 2022, 52 (3), 509–34.
- Glaeser, E. L.**, “The Political Economy of Hatred,” *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 2005, pp. 45–86.
- Granzier, R., V. Pons, and C. Tricaud**, “Coordination and Bandwagon Effects: How Past Rankings Shape the Behavior of Voters and Candidates,” *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, 2023, 15 (4), 177–217.
- Gregory, J. and A. Hermida**, “Congress of Racial Equality (CORE) Actions 1942–1970,” Mapping American Social Movements Project, University of Washington 2025. Last accessed October 13, 2025.
- and C. Molyneux, “CIO Unions: Mapping Locals and Membership 1938–1949,” Mapping American Social Movements Project, University of Washington 2025. Last accessed October 13, 2025.

- Haines, M.**, “Historical, Demographic, Economic, and Social Data: The United States, 1790-2002,” *Inter-university Consortium for Political and Social Research [distributor]*, Ann Arbor, MI, 2010-05-21. <https://doi.org/10.3886/ICPSR02896.v3>, 2010.
- Honey, M.**, “Operation Dixie: Labor and Civil Rights in the Postwar South,” *Mississippi Quarterly*, 1992, 45 (4), 439–52.
- Jackson, J. E.**, “Election Night Reporting and Voter Turnout,” *American Journal of Political Science*, 1983, 27 (4), 615–635.
- Kantor, S., P. V. Fishback, and J. J. Wallis**, “Did the New Deal Solidify the 1932 Democratic Realignment?,” *Explorations in Economic History*, 2013, 50 (4), 620–633.
- Katznelson, I.**, *When Affirmative Action Was White: An Untold History of Racial Inequality in Twentieth-Century America*, New York: W. W. Norton, 2005.
- Kestenbaum, L.**, “The Political Graveyard: The Internet’s Most Comprehensive Source of U.S. Political Biography,” <https://www.politicalgraveyard.com/>. Accessed 10/5/24., 2023.
- Kuziemko, E. and E. Washington**, “Why Did the Democrats Lose the South? Bringing New Data to an Old Debate,” *American Economic Review*, 2018, 108 (10).
- Lawson, S. F.**, *Black Ballots: Voting Rights in the South, 1944–1969*, New York: Columbia University Press, 1976.
- Lee, D. S., E. Moretti, and M. J. Butler**, “Do Voters Affect or Elect Policies? Evidence from the U. S. House,” *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 2004, 119 (3), 807–859.
- Lefgren, L., B. Platt, and J. Price**, “Sticking with What (Barely) Worked: A Test of Outcome Bias,” *Management Science*, 2015, 61 (5), 1121–1136.
- Lichtenstein, N.**, *State of the Union: A Century of American Labor*, Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2002.
- Little, A. T.**, “Are Non-competitive Elections Good for Citizens?,” *Journal of Theoretical Politics*, 2017, 29 (2), 214–42.
- Logan, L. D. and J. M. Parman**, “Segregation and Homeownership in the Early Twentieth Century,” *American Economic Review*, May 2017, 107 (5), 410–414.
- Magalhães, L. De**, “Incumbency Effects in a Comparative Perspective: Evidence from Brazilian Mayoral Elections,” *Political Analysis*, 2015, 23 (1), 113–26.
- Mazumder, S.**, “The Persistent Effect of U.S. Civil Rights Protests on Political Attitudes,” *American Journal of Political Science*, 2018, 62 (4), 922–935.
- McCrary, J.**, “Manipulation of the running variable in the regression discontinuity design: A density test,” *Journal of Econometrics*, 2008, 142, 698–714.
- Mehta, P. H. and R. A. Josephs**, “Testosterone Change after Losing Predicts the Decision to Compete Again,” *Hormones and Behavior*, 2006, 50 (5), 684–692.
- Meier, A. and E. Rudwick**, *CORE: A Study in the Civil Rights Movement, 1942–1968*, New York: Oxford University Press, 1973.

- Moon, H. L.**, *Balance of Power: The Negro Vote*, Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1948.
- Morris, A. D.**, *The Origins of the Civil Rights Movement: Black Communities Organizing for Change*, New York: Free Press, 1984.
- Morris, S. and H. S. Shin**, “Unique Equilibrium in a Model of Self-Fulfilling Currency Attacks,” *American Economic Review*, 1998, 88, 587–97.
- and —, “Global Games: Theory and Applications,” *Advances in Economics and Econometrics*, 2003, 88, 56–114.
- Page, L. and J. Coates**, “Winner and Loser Effects in Human Competitions: Evidence from Equally Matched Tennis Players,” *Evolution and Human Behavior*, 2017, 38 (4), 530–535.
- Pierce, L., T. Rogers, and J. A. Snyder**, “Losing Hurts: The Happiness Impact of Partisan Electoral Loss,” *Journal of Experimental Political Science*, 2016, 3 (1), 44–59.
- Robertson, I. H.**, *The Winner Effect: How Power Affects Your Brain*, London: Bloomsbury, 2012.
- Schickler, E.**, *Racial Realignment: The Transformation of American Liberalism, 1932–1965*, Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2016.
- Schroeder, J., D. Van Riper, S. Manson, K. Knowles, T. Kugler, F. Roberts, and S. Ruggles**, “IPUMS National Historical Geographic Information System: Version 20.0,” 2025. [dataset].
- Senninger, R., M. Baekgaard, and H. Seeberg**, “Unsuccessful Candidates Are More Concerned About Electoral Fairness than Election Winners,” *The Journal of Politics*, 2026, 88 (1).
- Simon, H. A.**, “Bandwagon and Underdog Effects and the Possibility of Election Predictions,” *Public Opinion Quarterly*, 1954, 18 (3), 245–253.
- Singh, S., I. Lago, and A. Blais**, “Winning and Competitiveness as Determinants of Political Support,” *Social Science Quarterly*, 2011, 92 (3), 695–709.
- Testa, P. A. and J. Williams**, “Political Foundations of Racial Violence in the Post-Reconstruction South,” *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 2025.
- U.S. Bureau of the Census**, *Census of Religious Bodies, 1936, Part I: Summary and Detailed Tables*, Washington, D.C.: Government Printing Office, 1940.
- Valelly, R. M.**, *The Two Reconstructions: The Struggle for Black Enfranchisement*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2004.
- Watson, D. L.**, *Lion in the Lobby: Clarence Mitchell Jr.’s Fight for the Passage of Civil Rights Laws*, Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans, 1990.
- Ziaja, S.**, “More Donors, More Democracy,” *The Journal of Politics*, 2020, 82 (2).
- Zilioli, S. and N. V. Watson**, “Testosterone across Successive Competitions: Evidence for a ‘Winner Effect’ in Humans?,” *Psychoneuroendocrinology*, 2014, 47, 1–9.

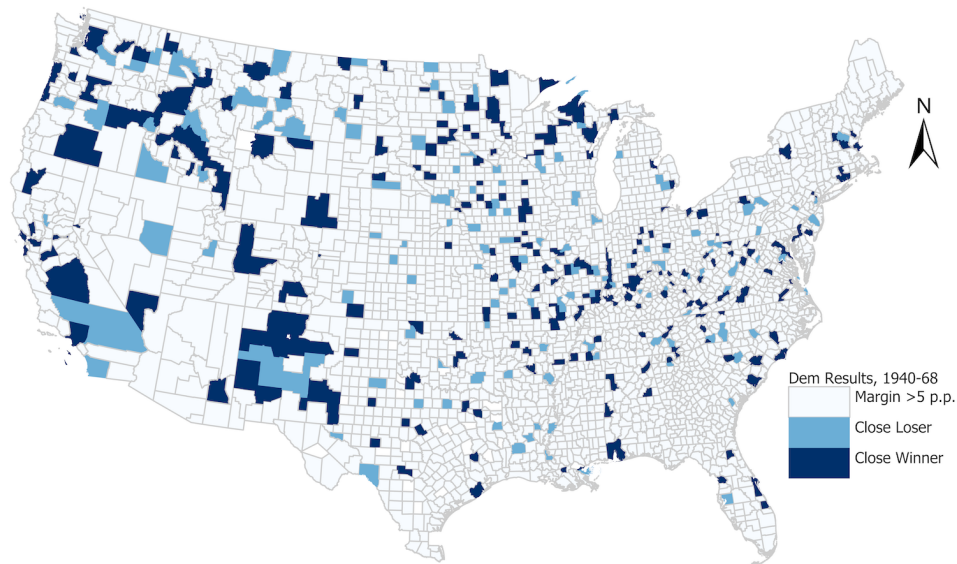
Figures and Tables

Figure 1: Change in Democratic Party Vote Shares, 1940 to 1972



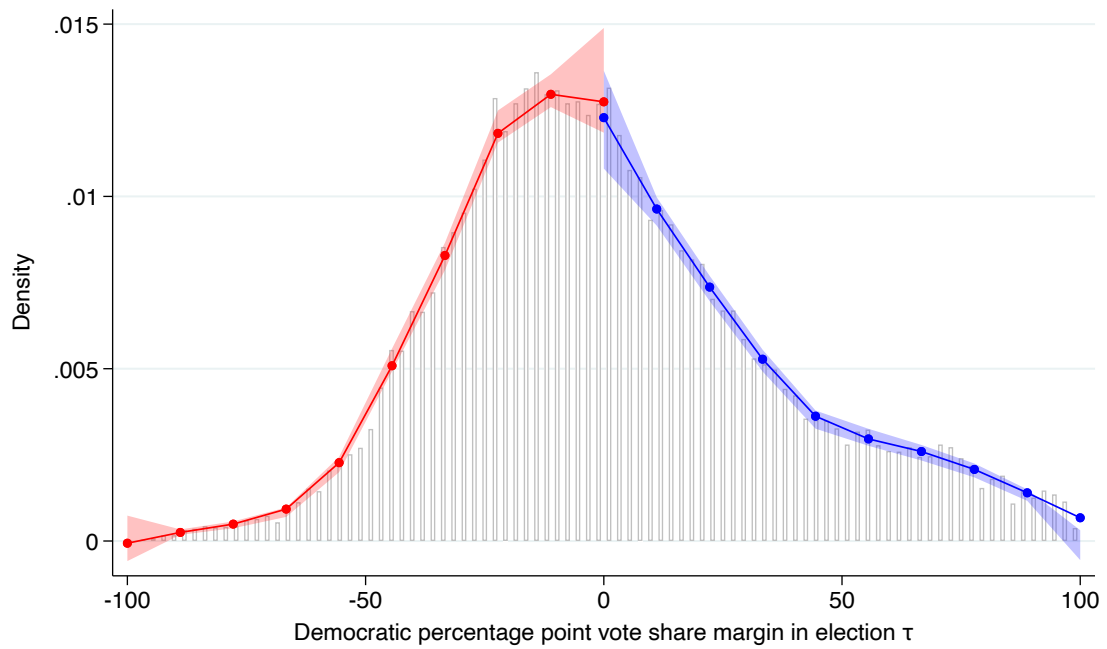
Notes: Map shows change in the spatial distribution of Democratic Party vote shares in presidential elections between 1940 and 1972. For the purpose of the figure, county boundaries are based on the 1960 U.S. Census.

Figure 2: Visualizing Sample Treatment Variation, 1940–68



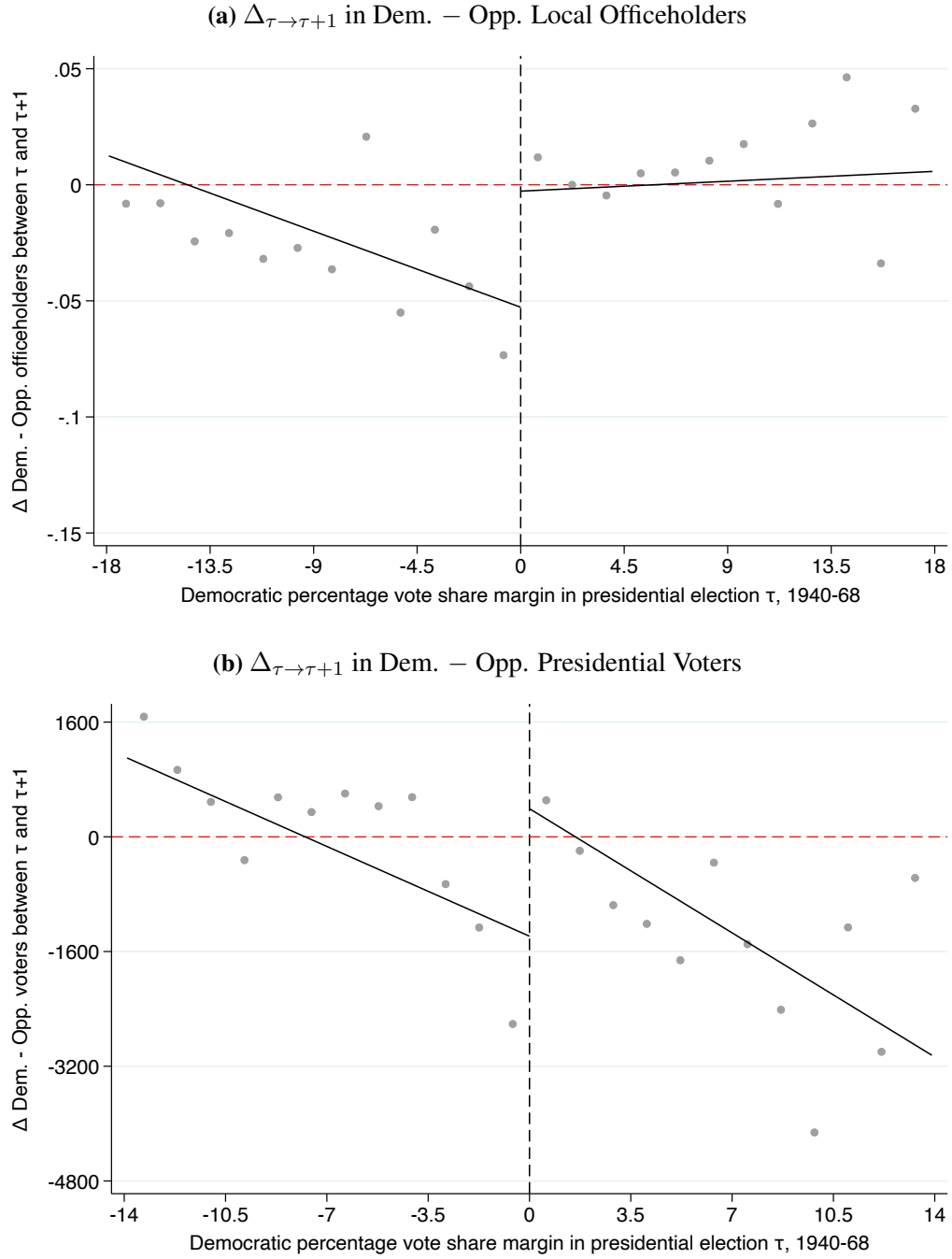
Notes: Map shows the distribution of close Democratic wins and losses, based on a very narrow 5 percentage point bandwidth, for sample counties over the 1940–68 period. Counties that experienced more than one narrow Democratic win during the sample period are shown in dark blue. Among those counties without any narrow Democratic wins, counties that experienced more than one narrow Democratic loss during the sample period are shown in light blue. Counties that experienced neither are shown in off-white. For the purpose of the figure, county boundaries are based on the 1960 U.S. Census.

Figure 3: Density Test in Democratic Presidential Vote Share Margins, 1940–1968



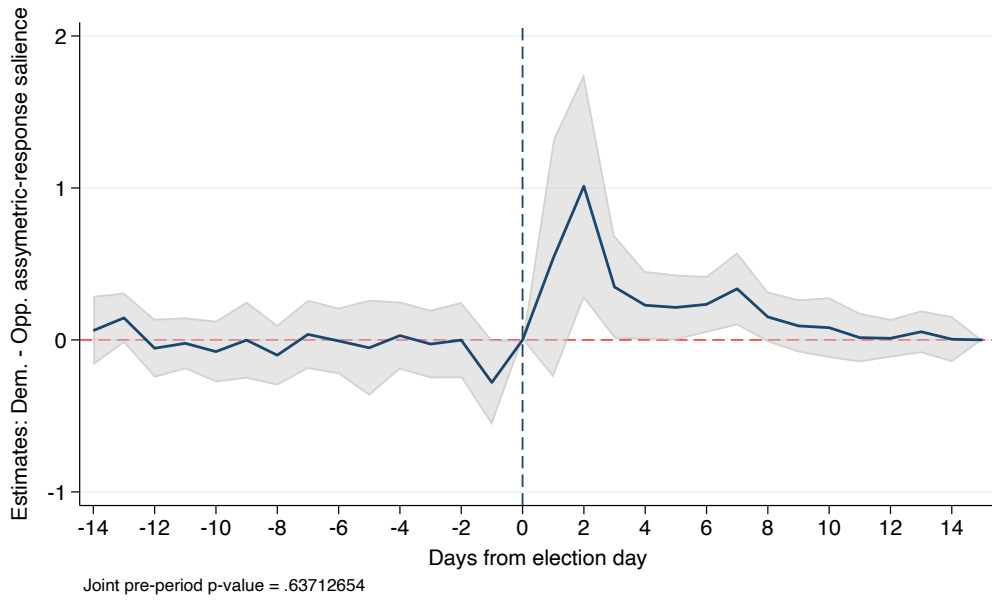
Notes: Figure illustrates the density test from Cattaneo et al. (2018) following McCrary (2008), using the Democratic vote share margin in presidential elections $\tau \in \{1940, \dots, 1968\}$ among counties ($p = 0.55$). Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals.

Figure 4: Change in Democratic Performance by Previous Election Margin, 1940–1968



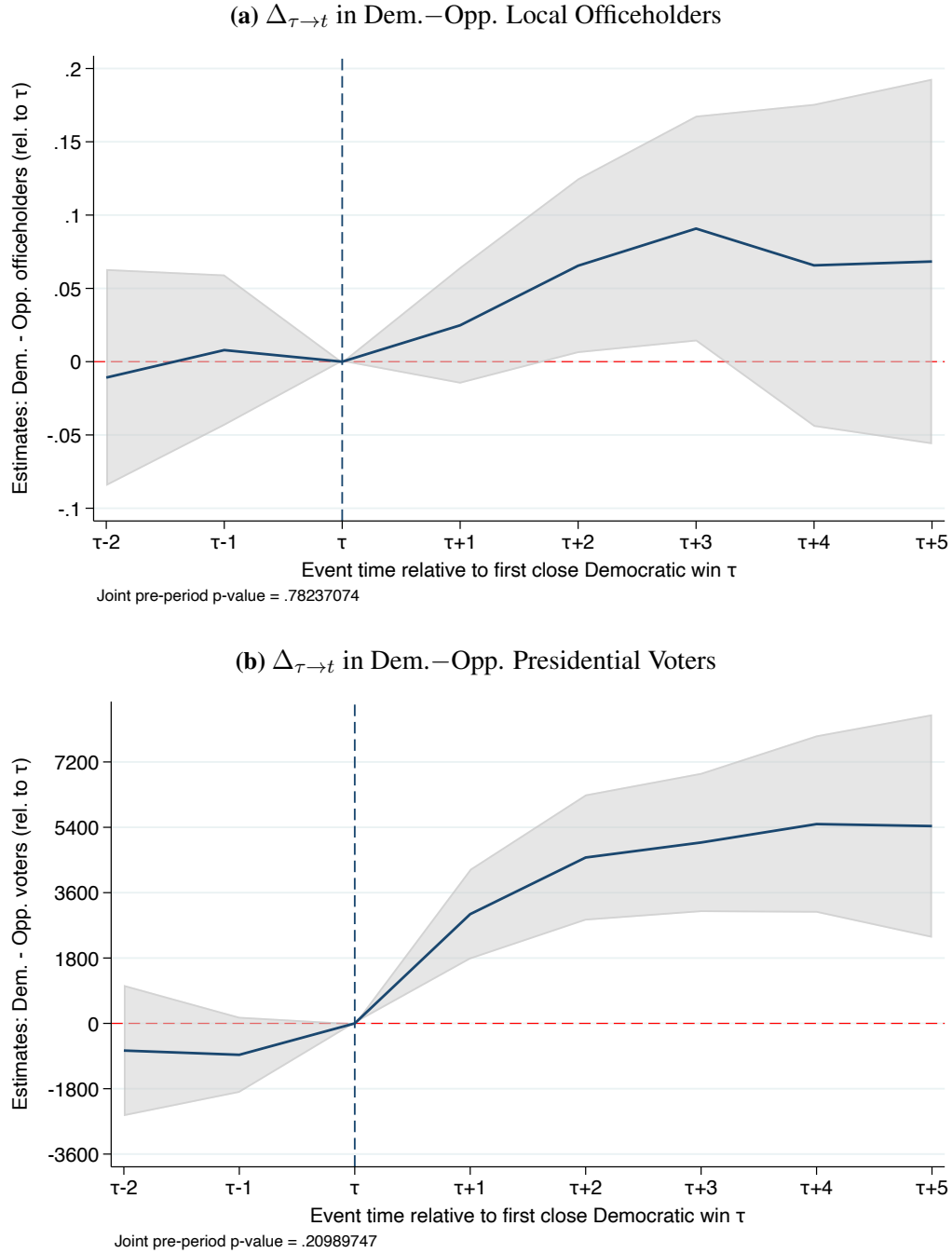
Notes: Binned estimates of the change in the Democratic Party’s relative performance in the number of (a) local officeholders and (b) presidential voters in a given county across the four-year election period following a presidential election τ , relative to the primary opposition in τ , over the Democratic vote share margin in $\tau \in \{1940, \dots, 1968\}$. Positive values on the x -axis indicate the Democratic candidate won a given county, while negative values indicate that they lost. All regressions include year fixed effects, state fixed effects, and quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude, as well as total (a) local officeholders and (b) presidential votes in τ . Bandwidth values on the x -axis based on the optimal bandwidths for each regression in Table 2. For RD estimates and associated p -value ranges, see Table 2.

Figure 5: Newspaper Sentiment of Popular Vote Outcomes in Counties, 1940–1968



Notes: Dynamic estimates of the discontinuity at vote share margins $V_{c\tau} = 0$ in the asymmetric-response salience index of local newspaper coverage, by day relative to presidential election day in $\tau \in \{1940, \dots, 1968\}$. The index equals celebratory-minus-mournful references to the Democratic side (its party or presidential nominee) net of the same for the county's primary opposition; see Appendix A.4 for its construction. Estimates are relative to the omitted election day ($t = 0$) and restrict to a 25 p.p. bandwidth, following a triangular kernel weighted inversely by a county's absolute Democratic vote share margin in τ , with all day dummies interacted with $V_{c\tau}$ and county-by-election and day fixed effects. The joint p -value for the null that all pre-election day estimates equal zero is reported at the base of the figure. Appendix Figure A.2 presents the Democratic and opposition components separately; Appendix Figure A.3 presents per-day RD counterparts.

Figure 6: Relative Changes in Democratic Performance Over Time, 1940–1968



Notes: Dynamic estimates of the Democratic Party’s relative performance in the number of (a) local officeholders and (b) presidential voters as of presidential election $\tau+y$, relative to the party’s primary opposition in presidential election $\tau \in \{1940, \dots, 1968\}$, over time $y = \{\dots, -1, 0, 1, 2, \dots\}$, based on a county’s first sample election with close Democratic win (defined as $V_{c\tau} \in [0, 25]$; see Appendix Table B.5 for estimates based on alternative upper bounds). All regressions include year and county fixed effects, with all event dummies interacted with $V_{c\tau}$. Estimation follows a triangular kernel, weighted inversely by a county’s absolute Democratic vote share margin relative to the primary opposition in τ . Average treatment effects are 0.07 (.02) in panel (a) and 1223.46 (559.32) in panel (b), as shown in column (3) of Appendix Table B.5.

Table 1: Regression Discontinuity Balance Tests: County Characteristics in 1940

Dependent Variable:	% Votes Democratic (1)	% Black Population (2)	Racial Dissimilarity (3)	Log Population Density (4)	% Labor Force, Men, 14+ (5)	% Labor Force, Women, 14+ (6)	Education, Men, 25+ (7)	Education, Women, 25+ (8)
Democrat Won County in Election τ	.510 (0.49)	.274 (0.46)	-.016 (0.018)	.001 (0.050)	-.265 (0.19)	-.139 (0.30)	.006 (0.045)	.001 (0.046)
Optimal bandwidth	15.96	23.65	18.77	25.53	19.62	21.69	19.90	20.67
Control outcome mean	55.36	6.58	0.53	2.40	78.55	18.40	8.00	8.55
Observations	9,095	12,996	10,404	13,846	11,029	11,994	11,169	11,528
Dependent Variable:	Any NAACP Chapters (9)	% Black Church Membership (10)	% Dwellings Owner-lived (11)	% Dwellings Nonwhite (12)	Med. Value of Dwellings (13)	Med. Rent of Tenants (14)	% Households w/ Electricity (15)	% Households w/ Radios (16)
Democrat Won County in Election τ	.020 (0.021)	.373 (0.53)	.436 (0.47)	.498 (0.53)	-33.717 (38.6)	-.082 (0.22)	-.153 (0.95)	-.392 (0.54)
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Spatial polynomial	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Optimal bandwidth	18.03	24.09	15.74	21.08	26.91	27.61	21.03	21.74
Running polynomial	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear
Control outcome mean	0.19	7.03	52.18	7.21	1740.00	12.06	59.58	74.78
Observations	10,269	13,156	9,011	11,716	14,186	14,511	11,713	12,043

Notes: This table reports bias-corrected local-polynomial RD estimates corresponding to equation (1) for various pre-treatment county-level characteristics. All characteristics are measured as of 1940. See Section 4.2 for more details on variables. Estimates based on linear running polynomials and the MSE-optimal bandwidth from Calonico et al. (2014). See Appendix Table B.1 for estimates based on quadratic running polynomials. All regressions include (election) year fixed effects, state fixed effects, and quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude. Standard errors are clustered at the county level and shown in parentheses. Significance levels are denoted by * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 2: Change in Democratic Performance After County Presidential Wins, 1940–68

Dependent Variable:	$\Delta_{\tau \rightarrow \tau+1}$ in ...					
	Dem. – Opp. (1)	(2)	Democratic (3)	(4)	Total (5)	(6)
(a) Local Officeholders						
Democrat Won County in Election τ	.055** (0.023)	.079*** (0.029)	.034** (0.015)	.037** (0.017)	.007 (0.029)	.005 (0.033)
$(\hat{\beta}/\text{offices}_{\tau}) \times 100$	9.6	14.0	6.0	6.7	1.3	0.9
Optimal bandwidth	18.31	22.68	18.03	26.90	22.02	29.37
Control outcome mean	-0.03	-0.03	-0.02	-0.02	-0.03	-0.03
Observations	10,411	12,491	10,261	14,373	12,212	15,368
(b) Presidential Voters						
Democrat Won County in Election τ	2118.39** (842.6)	2110.12** (895.5)	1326.44** (629.0)	1408.40** (714.5)	579.17 (572.8)	652.59 (689.5)
$(\hat{\beta}/\text{votes}_{\tau}) \times 100$	9.1	10.2	5.7	6.7	2.6	3.1
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Spatial polynomial	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Control for total value in τ	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Optimal bandwidth	13.60	29.78	13.81	27.28	18.46	27.72
Running polynomial	Linear	Quadratic	Linear	Quadratic	Linear	Quadratic
Control outcome mean	-67.84	495.93	681.46	915.40	1465.68	1472.16
Observations	7,815	15,524	8,008	14,525	10,455	14,739

Notes: This table reports bias-corrected local-polynomial RD estimates corresponding to equation (1) for the change in the Democratic Party's relative performance (columns 1–2) in the number of (a) local officeholders and (b) presidential voters in a given county across the four-year election period following a presidential election $\tau \in \{1940, \dots, 1968\}$, relative to the primary opposition in τ . Columns 3–4 use absolute performance, irrespective of opposition. Columns 5–6 consider overall changes. Estimates based on linear (odd columns) and quadratic (even) running polynomials and the MSE-optimal bandwidth from Calonico et al. (2014). All regressions include (election) year fixed effects, state fixed effects and quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude. Columns 1–4 also control for total (a) local officeholders and (b) presidential votes in τ . Standard errors are clustered at the county level and shown in parentheses. Significance levels are denoted by * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 3: Identification and Robustness Checks on RD Estimates in Table 2

Dependent Variable:	$\Delta_{\tau \rightarrow \tau+1}$ in Dem. – Opp. Local Officeholders (1)	$\Delta_{\tau \rightarrow \tau+1}$ in Dem. – Opp. Presidential Voters (2)
(a) Baseline Estimates		
1. Baseline (Column 1 of Table 2)	.055**	2118.39**
S.E. Clustered by County	(0.023)	(842.6)
S.E. Clustered by State	(0.020)	(768.7)
S.E. Clustered by State-Year	(0.026)	(1089.6)
(b) Alternative Control Sets		
2. No Year FE or Spatial Covariates	.057** (0.024)	2482.12*** (898.0)
3. No Spatial Covariates	.058** (0.024)	2660.83*** (879.5)
4. No Longitude and Latitude Controls	.055** (0.023)	2239.69*** (852.7)
5. Baseline w/ State-Year FE	.059** (0.025)	2174.79*** (834.5)
6. Controlling for All Variables from Table 1	.053** (0.024)	2404.45*** (929.6)
7. Baseline w/ County FE, Based on Unique County Boundaries	.057** (0.024)	2677.02*** (879.5)
(c) Alternative RD Specifications		
8. Fixed Bandwidth of 25 p.p.	.064** (0.025)	2209.77** (875.9)
9. $0.5 \times$ Optimal Bandwidth	.096*** (0.032)	2746.89*** (975.2)
10. $1.5 \times$ Optimal Bandwidth	.036* (0.020)	1360.71** (648.6)
11. Cubic Running Polynomial	.078*** (0.030)	2721.16*** (1016.3)
12. Quartic Running Polynomial	.098*** (0.036)	3507.72*** (1054.1)
(d) Restricted Samples		
13. Non-Southern Counties Only	.091** (0.043)	2971.54** (1416.6)
14. Southern Counties Only	.052** (0.026)	778.57 (567.0)
15. Republican Main Opposition Only	.066** (0.028)	1601.70* (885.9)
16. Top 2 Candidates w/ $>95\%$ of Vote	.060** (0.029)	1705.40* (1018.8)

Notes: This table reports bias-corrected local-polynomial RD estimates corresponding to equation (1) for the change in the Democratic Party's relative performance in the number of (a) local officeholders and (b) presidential voters in a given county across the four-year election period following a presidential election $\tau \in \{1940, \dots, 1968\}$, relative to the primary opposition in τ . Estimates based on linear running polynomials and the MSE-optimal bandwidth from Calonico et al. (2014), unless otherwise specified in panel (c). All regressions include election year fixed effects, state fixed effects, quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude, and total local officeholders (column 1) and presidential votes (column 2) in τ , unless otherwise specified in panel (b). Sample includes all counties in the conterminous U.S., except where specified in panel (d). See Section 4.3 for a more detailed overview of the items in each row. Standard errors are clustered at the county level and shown in parentheses, except where specified in panel (a). Significance levels are denoted by * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 4: Pre-Treatment Trends: Effects in Table 2 Using Placebo Outcomes

Dependent Variable:	$\Delta_{\tau \rightarrow \tau+1}$ in ...		$\Delta_{\tau-1 \rightarrow \tau}$ in ...		$\Delta_{\tau-2 \rightarrow \tau-1}$ in ...		$\Delta_{\tau-2 \rightarrow \tau}$ in ...	
	Dem. – Opp. (1)	Dem. (2)	Dem. – Opp. (3)	Dem. (4)	Dem. – Opp. (5)	Dem. (6)	Dem. – Opp. (7)	Dem. (8)
(a) Outcome Measure: Local Officeholders								
Democrat Won County in τ	.055** (0.023)	.034** (0.015)	-.014 (0.019)	-.020 (0.014)	-.004 (0.031)	.003 (0.016)	-.034 (0.039)	-.013 (0.020)
Optimal bandwidth	18.31	18.03	25.26	24.60	18.60	21.85	18.01	25.92
Control outcome mean	-0.03	-0.02	-0.02	-0.01	0.03	0.02	0.02	0.01
Observations	10,411	10,261	13,690	13,425	10,554	12,102	10,253	13,988
(b) Outcome Measure: Presidential Voters								
Democrat Won County in τ	2118.39** (842.6)	1326.44** (629.0)	-320.80 (482.9)	-123.47 (365.3)	-220.51 (592.4)	31.79 (342.6)	197.36 (677.0)	283.75 (412.1)
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Spatial polynomial	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Control for total value, τ	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Optimal bandwidth	13.60	13.81	25.30	32.81	18.39	22.11	15.07	16.76
Running polynomial	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear
Control outcome mean	-67.84	681.46	-1955.90	-428.30	86.30	674.20	-1838.10	327.00
Observations	7,815	8,008	13,741	16,621	10,403	12,239	8,637	9,571

Notes: This table reports bias-corrected local-polynomial RD estimates corresponding to equation (1) using placebo (pre-treatment) measures of the outcome. Columns 1 and 2 present the baseline estimates from column 1 and 3 of Table 2, respectively, based on relative and absolute changes in Democratic Party local officeholders (presidential votes) between τ and $\tau + 1$ for outcomes, respectively. The remaining columns re-estimate these using a variety of pre-treatment elections to test whether pre- τ trends in Democratic Party performance were relevant to the treatment in τ . Estimates based on linear running polynomials and the MSE-optimal bandwidth from Calonico et al. (2014). All regressions include (election) year fixed effects, state fixed effects, and quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude, with a control for total local officeholders (presidential votes) in τ throughout. Standard errors are clustered at the county level and shown in parentheses. Significance levels are denoted by * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 5: Micro-level Effects: Party Identification and Registration

Dependent Variable:	Identifies as Democrat			Registered + Democrat		
	All (1)	Black (2)	White (3)	All (4)	Black (5)	White (6)
Respondents:						
Democrat Won County in Election τ	.040* (0.024)	.272*** (0.046)	.035 (0.027)	.107*** (0.030)	.266*** (0.10)	.098** (0.048)
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Spatial polynomial	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Optimal bandwidth	12.06	13.40	12.12	13.02	12.98	13.76
Running polynomial	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear
Control outcome mean	0.81	0.70	0.82	0.47	0.62	0.46
Observations	4,035	424	3,660	2,554	220	2,330

Notes: This table reports bias-corrected local-polynomial RD estimates corresponding to equation (1) for a respondent's political identification (columns 1–3) and registration (columns 4–6) in a given county during the four-year election period following a presidential election $\tau \in \{1952, \dots, 1968\}$. Columns 2 and 5 (3 and 6) limit to Black (White) respondents in the American National Election Survey (ANES). Estimates based on linear running polynomials and the MSE-optimal bandwidth from [Calonico et al. \(2014\)](#). All regressions include (survey) year fixed effects, state fixed effects, quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude, and individual-level controls for sex and age fixed effects, while columns 1 and 4 control for race. Standard errors are clustered at the county level and shown in parentheses, except in columns 5–6, which are heteroskedasticity-robust. Significance levels are denoted by * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 6: Heterogeneous Effects: Conditioning on Organizational Geography

Dependent Variable: County Had [...]:	$\Delta_{\tau \rightarrow \tau+1}$ in Dem. – Opp. [...]									
	Any Incumbent Dem. Officeholders in τ		High Population Density in 1940		Any NAACP Chapters in 1940		High Black Church Membership in 1940		Any CIO Unions in 1940	
	Yes (1)	No (2)	Yes (3)	No (4)	Yes (5)	No (6)	Yes (7)	No (8)	Yes (9)	No (10)
(a) Outcome Measure: Local Officeholders										
Democrat Won County in Election τ	.312** (0.120)	-.003 (0.009)	.103** (0.044)	-.003 (0.011)	.313*** (0.11)	.004 (0.013)	.124*** (0.044)	.001 (0.023)	.159* (0.089)	.016 (0.011)
Optimal bandwidth	15.28	25.97	19.27	20.37	13.47	20.55	16.42	18.98	13.50	29.29
Split-sample p -value	0.02	0.02	0.04	0.04	0.01	0.01	0.03	0.03	0.16	0.16
Control outcome mean	-0.25	0.01	-0.05	-0.00	-0.12	-0.01	-0.04	-0.02	-0.09	-0.01
Observations	1,529	11,583	5,231	5,858	1,542	9,188	4,145	5,956	2,057	11,374
(b) Outcome Measure: Presidential Voters										
Democrat Won County in Election τ	10254.24** (4565.9)	434.25* (229.4)	3635.02** (1707.6)	-41.62 (134.4)	12185.98*** (4218.8)	-108.73 (261.5)	5231.38*** (1788.6)	-318.91 (541.9)	5658.76* (3029.1)	111.56 (183.9)
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Spatial polynomial	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Control for total value in τ	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Optimal bandwidth	12.72	18.54	13.14	17.07	11.36	20.52	11.83	15.39	13.76	15.62
Running polynomial	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear
Split-sample p -value	0.07	0.07	0.08	0.08	0.07	0.07	0.03	0.03	0.06	0.06
Control outcome mean	56.65	124.75	-59.35	-46.29	-91.67	12.84	-312.03	89.29	-146.68	-126.62
Observations	1,277	8,665	3,601	5,026	1,282	9,188	3,001	4,927	2,093	6,598

Notes: This table reports bias-corrected local-polynomial RD estimates for the change in the Democratic Party's relative performance in the number of (a) local officeholders and (b) presidential voters in a given county across the four-year election period following a presidential election $\tau \in \{1940, \dots, 1968\}$, relative to the primary opposition in τ . Estimates based on linear running polynomials and the MSE-optimal bandwidth from [Calonico et al. \(2014\)](#). The split-sample p -value corresponds to the null hypothesis that the difference between coefficients on *Dem. Margin_{cτ}* across subsamples is zero (e.g., between columns 1 and 2). All regressions include (election) year fixed effects, state fixed effects, quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude, and total (a) local officeholders and (b) presidential votes in τ . Standard errors are clustered at the county level and shown in parentheses. Significance levels are denoted by * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 7: Newspaper Advertising for Voter Registration

Dependent Variable:	Dem. – Rep. Registration Ads				Democratic Registration Ads			
	[. . .] Year After Election τ				All Years	Prior Cycle	All Years	Prior Cycle
	1st (1)	2nd (2)	3rd (3)	4th (4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Democrat Won County in τ	.013 (0.016)	.027* (0.016)	.013 (0.015)	.058*** (0.022)	.021*** (0.008)	-.001 (0.006)	.011*** (0.004)	-.005 (0.006)
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Spatial polynomial	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Optimal bandwidth	20.37	26.29	24.54	16.04	25.40	25.60	25.40	19.07
Running polynomial	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear
Control outcome mean	-0.00	-0.00	-0.00	-0.00	-0.00	-0.00	0.06	0.03
Observations	11,408	14,142	13,410	9,206	55,020	55,580	55,020	42,976

Notes: This table reports bias-corrected local-polynomial RD estimates corresponding to equation (1) for the number of local newspaper advertisements for party voter registration in a given county-year following a presidential election $\tau \in \{1940, \dots, 1968\}$. The outcome in columns 1–6 is the Democratic minus Republican count of such advertisements; in columns 7–8 it is the Democratic count alone. Columns 1–4 restrict to the first, second, third, and fourth year of the four-year election cycle following τ , respectively, while columns 5 and 7 pool all years in the cycle. Columns 6 and 8 report placebo estimates using the corresponding advertisement counts from the prior election cycle. Columns 1–4 trace how these effects evolve within the election cycle. Estimates based on linear running polynomials and the MSE-optimal bandwidth from [Calonico et al. \(2014\)](#). All regressions include (newspaper) year fixed effects, state fixed effects, quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude, and the total number of registration advertisements in the county-year. Standard errors are clustered at the county level and shown in parentheses. Significance levels are denoted by * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 8: Party Outreach and Selective Migration by Race

Dependent Variable:	Any Democratic Party Outreach		Mover is Black				
	Respondent is ...		Destination has ...				
	Black	White	Any NAACP Chapters		High % Black Churches		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	Yes (4)	No (5)	Yes (6)	No (7)
Democrat Won in τ	.472*** (0.085)	-.010 (0.026)	.024* (0.014)	.061*** (0.010)	.014 (0.009)	.038*** (0.012)	-.026* (0.016)
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Spatial polynomial	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Optimal bandwidth	10.67	14.99	10.53	9.86	8.30	10.61	9.83
Running polynomial	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear
Split-sample p -value	0.09	0.09	—	0.09	0.09	0.05	0.05
Control outcome mean	0.13	0.17	0.07	0.08	0.04	0.08	0.04
Observations	185	2,762	68,355	46,834	12,772	46,119	21,316

Notes: Columns 1–2 report bias-corrected local-polynomial RD estimates corresponding to equation (1) for whether direct contact was made with a respondent by the Democratic Party during the four-year election period following a presidential election $\tau \in \{1952, \dots, 1968\}$, limiting to Black (column 1) and White (column 2) respondents in the American National Election Studies (ANES) survey. Columns 3–7 report the corresponding estimates for whether a given individual who moved to county c in state s identified as Black in the U.S. Census, as a function of whether Democrats (barely) won the presidential vote in county c prior to the move. The migration sample in columns 3–7 consists of cross-state movers and presidential election years $\tau = \{1940, 1944, 1948, 1952, 1960, 1964\}$, such that migration to county c from a distinct location and after the election in question can be confirmed in the U.S. Census. Estimates based on linear running polynomials and the MSE-optimal bandwidth from Calonico et al. (2014). The split-sample p -value corresponds to the null hypothesis that the difference between coefficients on $Dem. Margin_{c\tau}$ across subsamples is zero (e.g., between columns 4 and 5). All regressions include (election or survey) year fixed effects, state fixed effects, and quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude, as well as individual-level controls for sex and age fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the county level and shown in parentheses, except in column 1, which is heteroskedasticity-robust. Significance levels are denoted by * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 9: Activism and Civil Rights Mobilization

Dependent Variable:	CORE Activity		Respondent Approves of...					
	Between		Participation		Civil		Political	
	τ and $\tau + 1$		in Protests		Disobedience		Demonstrations	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Democrat Won County in τ	.010** (0.005)	.011** (0.005)	.103** (0.040)	.226*** (0.049)	.221*** (0.065)	.307*** (0.052)	.315*** (0.040)	.258*** (0.060)
Unit of analysis	County		Individual		Individual		Individual	
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Spatial polynomial	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual controls	—	—	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Optimal bandwidth	19.51	28.88	11.00	16.12	7.17	11.50	12.65	13.26
Running polynomial	Linear	Quadratic	Linear	Quadratic	Linear	Quadratic	Linear	Quadratic
Control outcome mean	0.01	0.01	0.56	0.58	0.55	0.53	0.40	0.40
Observations	11,010	15,205	1,476	2,163	1,018	1,509	1,666	1,770

Notes: This table reports bias-corrected local-polynomial RD estimates corresponding to equation (1) for whether there was any Congress of Racial Equality (CORE) activity (columns 1–2) and support for protests, civil disobedience, and demonstrations by respondents (columns 3–8) during the four-year election period following a presidential election $\tau \in \{1940, \dots, 1968\}$. The ANES sample in columns 3–8 consists of presidential election years $\tau = \{1952, \dots, 1968\}$. Estimates based on linear (odd columns) and quadratic (even) running polynomials and the MSE-optimal bandwidth from Calonico et al. (2014). All regressions include (election or survey) year fixed effects, state fixed effects and quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude, while columns 3–8 include individual-level controls for sex, race, and age fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the county level and shown in parentheses. Significance levels are denoted by * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Online Appendix

A	Data and Variables	49
A.1	Summary Statistics	49
A.2	Coding Local Officeholders	51
A.3	Choice of Sample Period	52
A.4	Coding Newspaper Salience	54
A.5	Coding Newspaper Advertising	56
B	Additional Figures and Tables	58
C	A Theory of Elections and Strategic Coordination	66

List of Tables

A.1	Summary Statistics	49
A.2	Electoral Competition by Period, 1900–2020	53
B.1	Using Quadratic Running Variable in Table 1	60
B.2	Alternative Outcome Measures in Table 2	61
B.3	Heterogeneous Effects by Pre-Election Democratic Vote Trajectory	62
B.4	Placebo: Contemporaneous Local Officeholder Gains in Election τ	63
B.5	Dynamic Effects: Relative Changes in Democratic Performance Over Time	64
B.6	Electoral-College Footprint of the Winner Premium by Election τ	65

List of Figures

A.1	Democratic Vote Share Margins by Period, 1900–2020	52
A.2	Components of the Asymmetric-Response Salience Index, 1940–1968	55
A.3	RD Estimates of Asymmetric-Response Salience by Day, 1940–1968	55
A.4	Example of Democratic Party Advertising in Newspapers	57
B.1	Sensitivity Tests: Excluding Individual States and Election Years	58
B.2	Randomization Inference: Estimates from 1,000 Placebo Cutoffs	59

A Data and Variables

A.1 Summary Statistics

Table A.1: Summary Statistics

	Obs.	Mean	St. dev.	Min.	Max.
<i>(a) County-Level Variables</i>					
Political variables					
Δ (Dem. – Opp.) officeholders, τ to $\tau + 1$	13,593	-0.01	0.50	-8	11
Δ Democratic local officeholders, τ to $\tau + 1$	13,593	-0.01	0.33	-5	5
Δ local officeholders, τ to $\tau + 1$	13,593	-0.02	0.63	-17	15
Number of local officeholders, τ	13,606	0.59	1.86	0	42
Δ (Dem. – Opp.) voters, τ to $\tau + 1$	13,593	-590.73	16982.13	-450,505	633,962
Δ Democratic voters, τ to $\tau + 1$	13,593	340.65	10223.67	-344,890	400,477
Δ presidential voters, τ to $\tau + 1$	13,593	1488.90	10799.31	-264,673	472,707
Number of presidential votes, τ	13,606	25127.04	98561.81	11	2,730,918
Democratic vote share margin, τ	13,606	-2.38	13.69	-25	25
Other County Variables					
County longitude	13,606	-92.80	12.34	-124.16	-67.64
County latitude	13,606	39.22	4.63	25.42	48.83
Any CORE activity, τ to $\tau + 1$	13,606	0.01	0.10	0	1
% Democratic Party vote in 1940	13,513	56.99	15.75	13.09	100
% Black population in 1940	13,604	7.35	14.44	0	85.52
Racial dissimilarity index in 1940	13,359	0.53	0.33	0	1
Logged population density (per sqr. meter) in 1940	13,604	2.45	1.51	-3.50	10.36
Labor force participation, men 14+, 1940	13,574	78.68	4.11	42.02	97.44
Labor force participation, women 14+, 1940	13,574	18.47	6.50	4.60	47.90
Median educational attainment, men 25+, 1940	13,574	7.94	1.87	0	99.90
Median educational attainment, women 25+, 1940	13,574	8.48	1.93	0	99.90
Any NAACP chapters, 1940	13,604	0.20	0.40	0	1
Per capita Black church members, 1940	13,570	7.92	16.26	0	92.45
Any CIO Unions, 1940	13,604	0.26	0.44	0	1
% Owner-occupied dwellings, 1940	13,573	51.57	10.52	1.20	85
% Non-white occupied dwellings, 1940	13,574	8	14.31	0	86.20
Median value of owner-occupied dwellings, 1940	13,383	1715.10	1001.86	192	13,163
Median monthly rent of tenant dwellings, 1940	13,417	11.92	5.94	1.38	45.41
% Households with electricity, 1940	13,571	58.88	24.09	0	99.80
% Households with radio, 1940	13,570	73.65	17.93	13.20	98.50

Notes: Table provides summary statistics for variables based on counties between the 1940 and 1968 presidential election periods, restricting to a bandwidth of 25 p.p. so as to focus on relatively competitive county-election observations. Continued in panel (b) on the following page.

Table A.1: Summary Statistics (Continued)

	Obs.	Mean	St. dev.	Min.	Max.
<i>(b) Other Variables</i>					
Survey data variables					
Respondent identifies as Democrat	7,906	0.57	0.50	0	1
Respondent is registered to vote and identifies as Democrat	4,531	0.47	0.50	0	1
Respondent contacted by the Democratic Party	4,816	0.16	0.36	0	1
Respondent approves of participation in protests	2,982	0.57	0.50	0	1
Respondent approves of civil disobedience	2,982	0.52	0.50	0	1
Respondent approves of demonstrations	2,979	0.41	0.49	0	1
Newspaper variables					
(Dem. — Rep.) newspapers advertisements	54,424	-0.00	0.39	-8	8
Number of Democratic Party newspapers advertisements	54,424	0.06	0.36	0	12
Number of newspapers advertisements in year	54,424	0.13	0.59	0	18
(Dem. — Opp.) asymmetric-response salience index	534,520	-0.03	1.42	-138	90
Democratic response salience	534,520	0.26	1.47	-21	186
Republican response salience	534,520	0.30	1.60	-21	172
Number of articles mentioning electoral outcome in day	534,520	0.68	3.11	0	330
Migration variables					
Mover is Black	156,657	0.07	0.25	0	1

Notes: Continued from panel (a) on the preceding page. Survey variables are measured at the respondent level in the American National Election Studies (ANES); newspaper variables at the newspaper-year level; and migration variables at the level of individual cross-state movers in the U.S. Census. All statistics restrict to a bandwidth of 25 p.p. so as to focus on relatively competitive county-election observations.

A.2 Coding Local Officeholders

I use the universe of data from the Political Graveyard ([Kestenbaum, 2023](#)), adapted from [Bazzi et al. \(2025\)](#). The dataset contains biographical and career records for historical U.S. officeholders, with each individual's full career description stored as a single semicolon-delimited string. I parse this string to identify party affiliation (e.g., "Democrat") as well as whether each individual ever held one of the following local office categories:

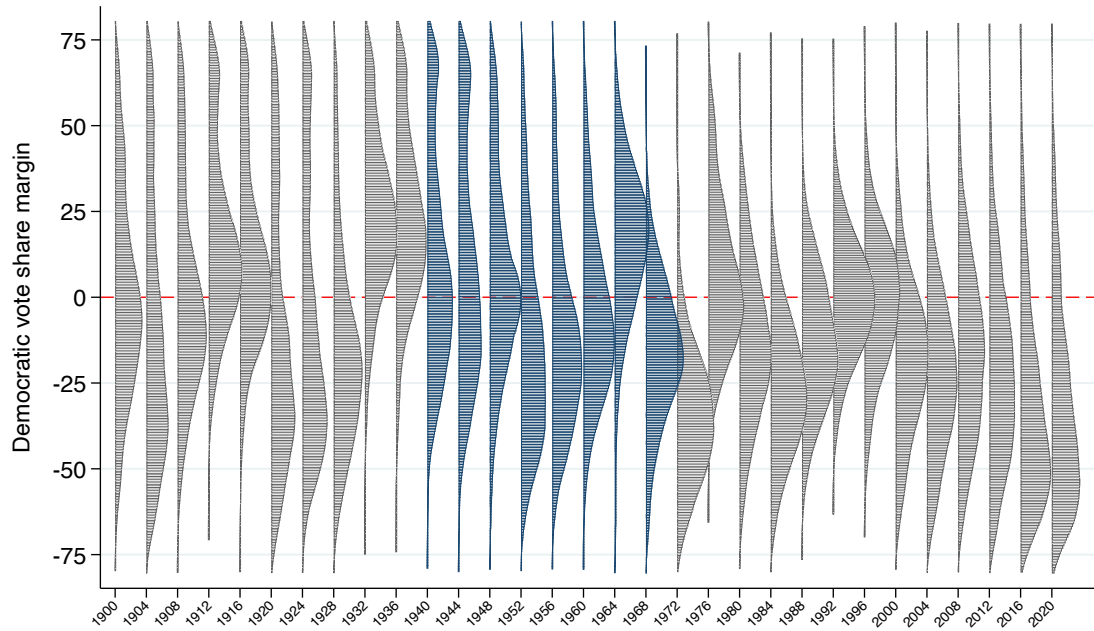
- **Executive/municipal leadership:** mayor, city manager, county president, city president, borough president, town president, village president, burgess, first selectman, intendant
- **Law enforcement:** sheriff, chief of police, police chief
- **Council/legislative:** alderman, city council, town council, county council
- **Commission:** commissioner, town commission, city commission, county commission
- **Clerk/administration:** assessor, clerk, recorder, election supervisor
- **Boards/education:** board of supervisors, school board
- **Postal appointment:** postmaster

For each office category, I construct three variables: an indicator for whether the individual ever held the office, and the earliest starting year and latest ending year across all held terms, where available. Years are extracted from the semicolon-delimited segment containing the relevant office keyword. When the source records a year range with an abbreviated two-digit end year (e.g., "1941–43"), I expand the end year using the century of the start year. When only a single year appears, it is coded as both the start and end year. If a segment contains the office keyword but no year information, the indicator is set to one and the year variables remain missing.

I then stack the person-level data into a county-by-election-year panel, where each observation records the count of local officeholders active in a given county as of the beginning of an election year, both overall and by party. An individual is coded as active in a given election year if their start year precedes that year (i.e., they were active on January 1).

A.3 Choice of Sample Period

Figure A.1: Democratic Vote Share Margins by Period, 1900–2020



Notes: Figure shows distributions of county Democratic vote share margins in presidential elections between 1900 and 2020. The sample period for the main analysis (1940–1968, blue) is characterized by a particularly sustained period of competitive county-level outcomes across the U.S.

Table A.2: Electoral Competition by Period, 1900–2020

Period	Competition	Notes	Mean (St. dev.)
1900–1928	Lower within-county, Higher cross-region competition	South solidly Democratic North solidly Republican. Exception: 1912 and 1916 (Wilson) competitive in North.	4.85 (41.45)
1932–1936	Lower competition everywhere	Roosevelt sweeps both regions in both elections.	36.35 (35.28)
1940–1968	Higher competition everywhere	Democrats become more competitive in North; South begins to splinter for Democrats.	1.30 (34.69)
1972	Lower competition everywhere	Nixon sweep.	-33.64 (21.12)
1976–1980	Higher competition everywhere	North shifts blue, South shifts red; both regions contested.	-3.70 (25.22)
1984	Lower competition everywhere	Reagan sweep.	-25.63 (20.88)
1988–1996	Higher competition everywhere	North shifts blue, South shifts red; both regions contested.	-4.66 (20.67)
2000–2020	Lower within-county, higher cross-county competition	Democrats strong in cities and coasts; Republicans dominant everywhere else. Counties less competitive individually; national races closely divided.	-23.40 (28.82)

Notes: This table summarizes patterns of county-level electoral competition across presidential elections, corresponding to Appendix Figure A.1. “Competition” refers to the spread of the county-level Democratic vote share margin distribution: higher competition corresponds to more counties near the zero-margin threshold. Means and standard deviations correspond to average Democratic vote share margins across counties during a period. The sample period for the main analysis (1940–1968, bolded) is characterized by a particularly sustained period of competitive county-level outcomes across the U.S.

A.4 Coding Newspaper Salience

To measure how the local press framed outcomes of presidential elections in counties, I rely on full-text newspaper page images digitized at newspapers.com. For each presidential election $\tau \in \{1940, \dots, 1968\}$, I search for pages published in the days and weeks just before and just after an election which pair an outcome phrase with a party or its presidential nominee. Such outcome phrases fall into two categories:

- **Celebratory (winning):** “victor*” (e.g., victory, victories, victor, victorious), “triumph*”, “win”, “wins”, “won”
- **Mournful (losing):** “loss”, “lose*” (lose, loses, loser, losing)

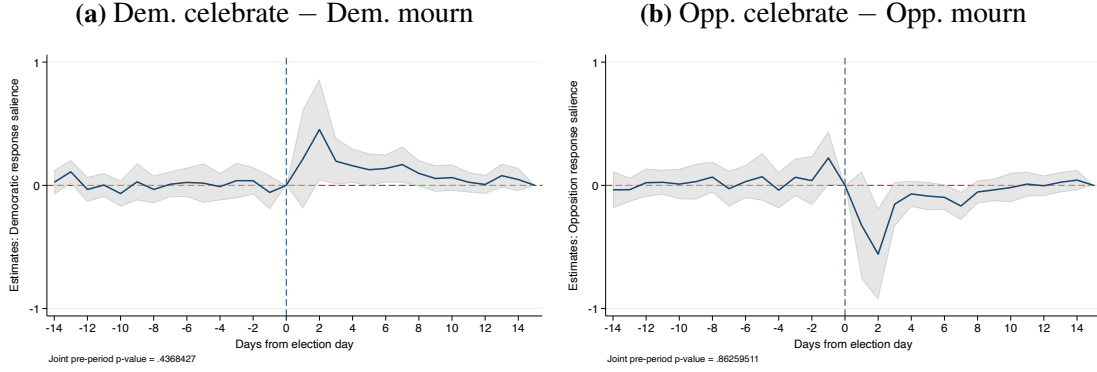
I then pair each phrase with (i) each major party (“democrat*”, “republican”) and (ii) each cycle’s presidential nominees, including the prominent third-party candidates Strom Thurmond (1948) and George Wallace (1968), who each carried counties across the South. The 1948 searches, for instance, include “truman won”, “dewey loss”, and “thurmond victor*”. Each search returns a set of newspaper pages; I drop pages matching more than one phrase, geolocate each newspaper to a county, and count the number of matching pages per county-day.

For a given county-day, let D^+ and D^- denote the counts of celebratory and mournful pages referencing the Democratic side (its party or nominee), and let O^+ and O^- denote the analogous counts for the county’s primary opposition. The primary opposition is the Republican Party and its nominee, except in counties where a third-party candidate was the runner-up (Thurmond in 1948, Wallace in 1968), for which the opposition counts reference that candidate instead. The asymmetric-response salience index is thus

$$\text{ARSI}_{cd} = \underbrace{(D^+ - D^-)}_{\text{Dem. celebrate} - \text{Dem. mourn}} - \underbrace{(O^+ - O^-)}_{\text{Opp. celebrate} - \text{Opp. mourn}},$$

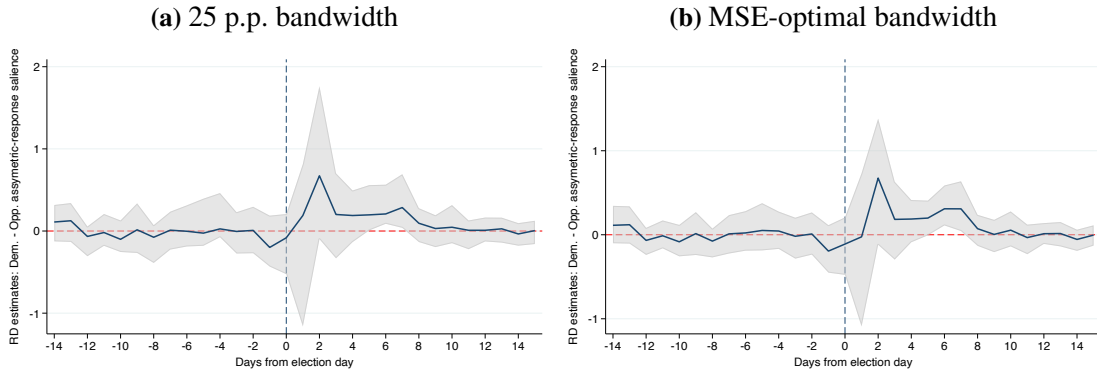
measured for each county c and day d relative to election day ($d = 0$). Positive values indicate that the Democratic side received relatively more celebratory, and less mournful, coverage than its primary opposition. Appendix Figures A.2 and A.3 report the components of the index and RD-based counterparts to Figure 5, respectively.

Figure A.2: Components of the Asymmetric-Response Salience Index, 1940–1968



Notes: Dynamic estimates of the discontinuity at $V_{c\tau} = 0$ in the two components of the asymmetric-response salience index: (a) celebratory-minus-mournful references to the Democratic side, and (b) the same for the county's primary opposition, by day relative to election day in $\tau \in \{1940, \dots, 1968\}$. Their difference is the index plotted in Figure 5. Specifications match that figure: estimates are relative to the omitted election day ($t = 0$), restrict to a 25 p.p. bandwidth, follow a triangular kernel weighted inversely by a county's absolute Democratic vote share margin in τ , and include county-by-election and day fixed effects with all day dummies interacted with $V_{c\tau}$. The joint p -value for the null that all pre-election day estimates equal zero is reported at the base of each panel.

Figure A.3: RD Estimates of Asymmetric-Response Salience by Day, 1940–1968



Notes: Per-day local-polynomial RD estimates of the discontinuity at $V_{c\tau} = 0$ in the asymmetric-response salience index, estimating a separate regression for each day relative to election day in $\tau \in \{1940, \dots, 1968\}$, using (a) a fixed 25 p.p. bandwidth and (b) the MSE-optimal bandwidth of [Calonico et al. \(2014\)](#). Both include year fixed effects, state fixed effects, quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude, and the total number of newspaper matches per county-day, with standard errors clustered at the county level. This is the per-day RD counterpart to the pooled event study in Figure 5.

A.5 Coding Newspaper Advertising

To measure top-down party investment in voter mobilization, I build a county-year panel of party-registration advertising in local newspapers, again using full-text page images digitized at newspapers.com. I search for pages containing any of five registration-drive phrases directed at a party. For the Democratic Party, these are:

- “register as a democrat”
- “you can register democrat*”
- “are you registered democrat*”
- “change from republican to democrat*”
- “switch from republican to democrat*”

with a symmetric set for the Republican Party (e.g., “register as a republican”, “change from democrat* to republican”). Ads using such phrasing were clearly partisan and persuasion-oriented; Figure A.4 shows a representative example. Each search returns a set of newspaper pages, which I geolocate to a county and count by county and calendar year.

Let A_{cy}^D and A_{cy}^R denote the number of Democratic and Republican registration-advertising pages in county c and year y . The primary advertising outcome is the net Democratic count, $A_{cy}^D - A_{cy}^R$, with the Democratic count A_{cy}^D alone used as an alternative; the total $A_{cy}^D + A_{cy}^R$ enters as a control. Because a four-year election period spans several calendar years, I index each year by its position within the cycle following a presidential election τ (the first through fourth year), which allows the analysis in Table 7 to trace how advertising responses to a close Democratic win evolve over the cycle.

Figure A.4: Example of Democratic Party Advertising in Newspapers



**REGISTER
DEMOCRATIC**
AND BE ON THE WINNING TEAM

You Can Register Democratic
or change from Republican to Democratic

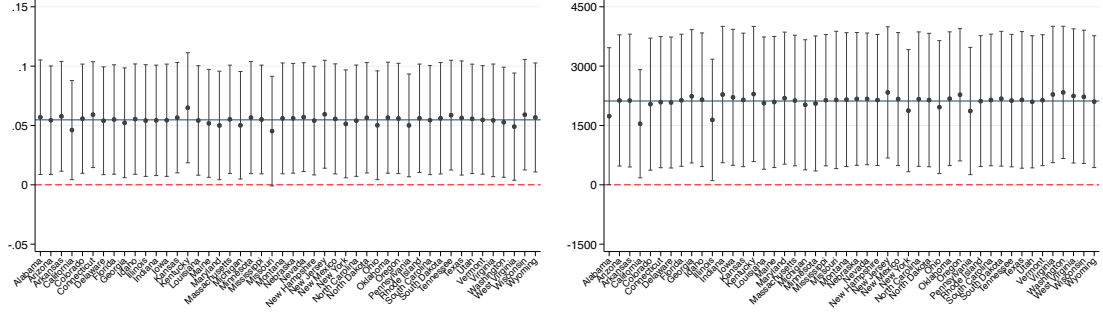
TODAY
From 2 to 6 and 7 to 9 p. m.
AT THE
PUNXSUTAWNEY MUNICIPAL BUILDING
JEFFERSON COUNTY DEMOCRATIC COMMITTEE
BRUCE MILLIRIN, Chairman

Notes: An example of newspaper data generated by two of the keywords used, “change+from+republican+to+democrat*” and “you+can+register+democrat*,” as featured on page seven of the *Punxsutawney Spirit* on March 23, 1962. Clipping screencapped from newspapers.com.

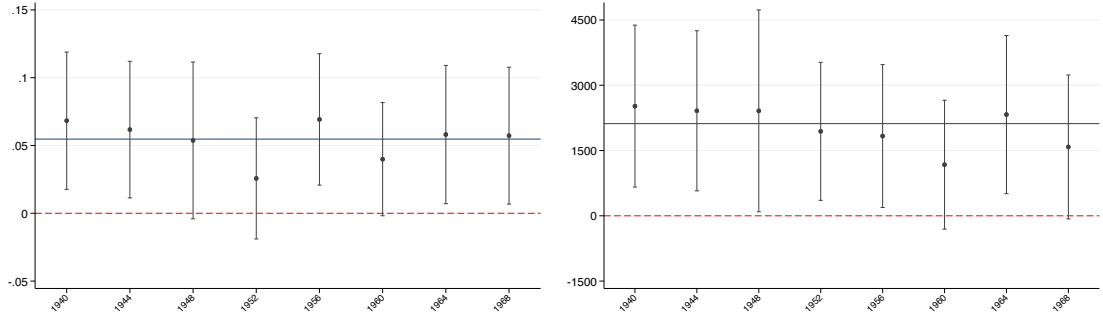
B Additional Figures and Tables

Figure B.1: Sensitivity Tests: Excluding Individual States and Election Years

(a) Excluding States: (i) $\Delta_{\tau \rightarrow \tau+1}$ Dem—Opp Officeholders and (ii) $\Delta_{\tau \rightarrow \tau+1}$ Dem—Opp Voters



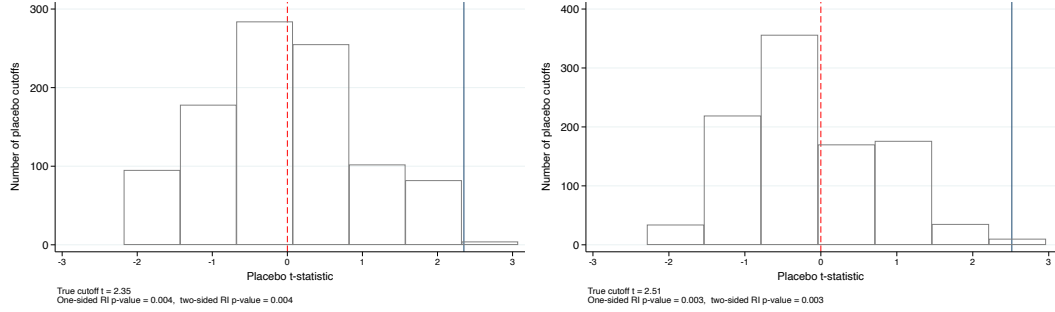
(b) Excluding Elections: (i) $\Delta_{\tau \rightarrow \tau+1}$ Dem—Opp Officeholders and (ii) $\Delta_{\tau \rightarrow \tau+1}$ Dem—Opp Voters



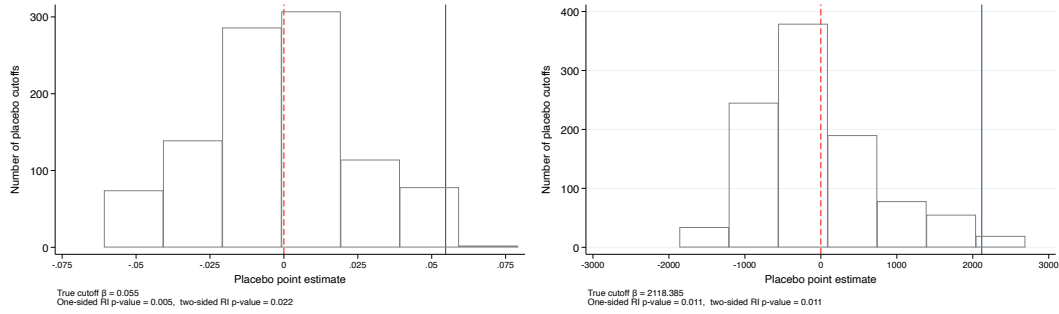
Notes: RD estimates of the change in the Democratic Party's relative performance in the number of (a) local officeholders and (b) presidential voters in a given county across the four-year election period following a presidential election τ , relative to the primary opposition in τ . Panel (a) excludes sample states one-by-one, holding all other aspects of the specification fixed, where the excluded state is reported on the x -axis. Panel (b) excludes sample election periods one-by-one, all else fixed, where the excluded election is reported on the x -axis. All regressions include (election) period fixed effects, state fixed effects, quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude, and total (i) local officeholders and (ii) presidential votes in τ . Compare estimates to column 1 in Table 2. Standard errors are clustered at the county level. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals.

Figure B.2: Randomization Inference: Estimates from 1,000 Placebo Cutoffs

(a) T-statistics: (i) $\Delta_{\tau \rightarrow \tau+1}$ Dem–Opp Officeholders and (ii) $\Delta_{\tau \rightarrow \tau+1}$ Dem–Opp Voters



(b) Point estimates: (i) $\Delta_{\tau \rightarrow \tau+1}$ Dem–Opp Officeholders and (ii) $\Delta_{\tau \rightarrow \tau+1}$ Dem–Opp Voters



Notes: This figure reports the distribution of placebo RD estimates from 1,000 evenly spaced cutoffs over the support of the running variable, following the permutation test of [Ganong and Jager \(2018\)](#). Panel (a) plots placebo t-statistics (β/SE) and panel (b) plots placebo point estimates (β) for the change in the Democratic Party's relative performance in the number of (i) local officeholders and (ii) presidential voters. Given an actual threshold of $V_{c\tau} = 0$, each placebo estimate corresponds to equation (1) evaluated at a false cutoff $V_{c\tau} + \rho$, where ρ ranges from -25 to 25 p.p., holding all other aspects of the specification fixed. All regressions include (election) year fixed effects, state fixed effects, quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude, and controls for total local officeholders (i) or presidential votes (ii) in τ . Standard errors are clustered at the county level. The solid vertical line marks the estimate at the true cutoff. One-sided randomization inference p -values report the share of placebo estimates at least as large as the true estimate; two-sided p -values report the share with absolute value at least as large.

Table B.1: Using Quadratic Running Variable in Table 1

Dependent Variable:	% Votes Democratic (1)	% Black Population (2)	Racial Dissimilarity (3)	Log Population Density (4)	% Labor Force, Men, 14+ (5)	% Labor Force, Women, 14+ (6)	Education, Men, 25+ (7)	Education, Women, 25+ (8)
Democrat Won County in Election τ	.588 (0.51)	-.068 (0.64)	-.020 (0.019)	.013 (0.057)	-.300 (0.21)	-.160 (0.31)	.010 (0.048)	.010 (0.056)
Optimal bandwidth	27.99	24.67	31.06	33.02	26.14	36.75	30.37	27.56
Control outcome mean	53.37	6.47	0.53	2.37	78.54	18.33	8.03	8.56
Observations	14,727	13,437	15,742	16,714	14,061	17,822	15,716	14,635
Dependent Variable:	Any NAACP Chapters (9)	% Black Church Membership (10)	% Dwellings Owner-lived (11)	% Dwellings Nonwhite (12)	Med. Value of Dwellings (13)	Med. Rent of Tenants (14)	% Households w/ Electricity (15)	% Households w/ Radios (16)
Democrat Won County in Election τ	.021 (0.021)	-.111 (0.74)	.639 (0.50)	.251 (0.71)	-40.014 (46.3)	-.053 (0.26)	-.118 (1.06)	-.126 (0.63)
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Spatial polynomial	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Optimal bandwidth	32.36	24.27	26.22	24.83	29.89	33.23	29.17	26.98
Running polynomial	Quadratic	Quadratic	Quadratic	Quadratic	Quadratic	Quadratic	Quadratic	Quadratic
Control outcome mean	0.17	7.03	52.42	7.06	1743.11	12.06	59.97	75.08
Observations	16,472	13,245	14,106	13,497	15,308	16,533	15,264	14,385

Notes: This table reports bias-corrected local-polynomial RD estimates corresponding to equation (1) for various pre-treatment county-level characteristics. All characteristics are measured as of 1940. See Section 4.2 for more details on variables. Estimates based on quadratic running polynomials and the MSE-optimal bandwidth from Calonico et al. (2014). All regressions include (election) year fixed effects, state fixed effects, and quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude. Standard errors are clustered at the county level and shown in parentheses. Significance levels are denoted by * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B.2: Alternative Outcome Measures in Table 2

Dependent Variable:	% Dem. Local Officeholders at $\tau + 1$		Δ % Dem. Local Officeholders, τ to $\tau + 1$		Δ % (Dem. - Opp.) Local Officeholders, τ to $\tau + 1$		% Dem. Presidential Voters at $\tau + 1$		Δ % Dem. Presidential Voters, τ to $\tau + 1$		Δ % (Dem. - Opp.) Presidential Voters, τ to $\tau + 1$	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)	(11)	(12)
Democrat Won County in Election τ	8.978** (4.00)	8.011* (4.80)	5.466** (2.55)	6.147* (3.29)	5.606 (3.96)	8.078 (5.15)	1.765*** (0.63)	2.833*** (0.68)	1.329*** (0.50)	2.331*** (0.59)	5.235*** (1.64)	8.05*** (1.88)
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Spatial polynomial	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Optimal bandwidth	20.68	25.56	21.10	25.08	23.67	25.28	10.22	19.50	11.48	19.00	10.24	17.72
Running polynomial	Linear	Quadratic	Linear	Quadratic	Linear	Quadratic	Linear	Quadratic	Linear	Quadratic	Linear	Quadratic
Control outcome mean	47.16	47.21	-3.25	-3.15	-5.41	-5.23	44.17	42.71	-1.69	-0.79	-187.90	151.77
Observations	2,631	3,138	2,408	2,767	2,644	2,787	6,005	10,943	6,667	10,695	6,005	10,101

Notes: This table reports bias-corrected local-polynomial RD estimates corresponding to equation (1) using alternative measures of the outcome. Columns 1–2 (7–8) uses the share of Democratic local officeholders (presidential votes) at election $\tau + 1$; columns 3–4 (9–10) use the percentage point change in the share of Democratic local officeholders (presidential votes) between τ and $\tau + 1$; and columns 5–6 (11–12) use the percentage point change in the Democratic Party's relative performance in the share of local officeholders (presidential votes) between τ and $\tau + 1$, relative to the primary opposition in τ . Estimates based on linear (odd columns) and quadratic (even) running polynomials and the MSE-optimal bandwidth from Calonico et al. (2014). All regressions include (election) year fixed effects, state fixed effects, and quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude. Standard errors are clustered at the county level and shown in parentheses. Significance levels are denoted by * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B.3: Heterogeneous Effects by Pre-Election Democratic Vote Trajectory

Dependent Variable:	$\Delta_{\tau \rightarrow \tau+1}$ in Dem. – Opp. Local Officeholders				$\Delta_{\tau \rightarrow \tau+1}$ in Dem. – Opp. Presidential Voters			
	$\tau - 1$ to τ		$\tau - 2$ to τ		$\tau - 1$ to τ		$\tau - 2$ to τ	
Trajectory Measured Over:	< 0	≥ 0	< 0	≥ 0	< 0	≥ 0	< 0	≥ 0
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Democrat Won County in τ	.051*	.040	.030	.050	2061.97**	916.37	1940.43*	1319.11
	(0.028)	(0.047)	(0.026)	(0.041)	(977.8)	(1131.6)	(1029.2)	(1378.1)
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Spatial polynomial	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Control for total value in τ	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Optimal bandwidth	16.80	18.45	19.09	21.70	16.01	18.77	14.91	14.35
Running polynomial	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear	Linear
Split-sample p -value	0.99	0.99	0.58	0.58	0.80	0.80	0.95	0.95
Control outcome mean	-0.05	0.01	-0.05	0.02	-692.17	1519.49	-64.91	307.09
Observations	5,757	4,187	6,609	4,622	5,534	4,243	5,306	3,151

Notes: This table reports bias-corrected local-polynomial RD estimates corresponding to equation (1) for the change in the Democratic Party's relative performance in the number of local officeholders (columns 1–4) and presidential voters (columns 5–8) in a given county across the four-year election period following a presidential election $\tau \in \{1940, \dots, 1968\}$, relative to the primary opposition in τ . Each pair of columns splits the sample by the county's *pre-election* trajectory in Democratic performance, defined as the change in the Democratic relative to opposition presidential vote count between a prior election and τ , measured over either one election period ($\tau - 1$ to τ) or two ($\tau - 2$ to τ). Odd columns limit to counties on a declining trajectory coming into τ ; even columns to those on a flat or rising trajectory. Estimates based on linear running polynomials and the MSE-optimal bandwidth from Calonico et al. (2014). The split-sample p -value corresponds to the null hypothesis that the difference between coefficients on $Dem. Margin_{c\tau}$ across subsamples is zero (e.g., between columns 1 and 2). All regressions include (election) year fixed effects, state fixed effects, quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude, and total local officeholders (columns 1–4) and presidential votes (columns 5–8) in τ . Standard errors are clustered at the county level and shown in parentheses. Significance levels are denoted by * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B.4: Placebo: Contemporaneous Local Officeholder Gains in Election τ

Dependent Variable:	Dem. – Opp. Local Officeholders Elected in Election τ	
	(1)	(2)
Democrat Won County in Election τ	-.027 (0.032)	-.005 (0.044)
Year FE	Yes	Yes
State FE	Yes	Yes
Spatial polynomial	Yes	Yes
Optimal bandwidth	26.41	26.13
Running polynomial	Linear	Quadratic
Control outcome mean	-0.14	-0.14
Observations	14,222	14,095

Notes: This table reports bias-corrected local-polynomial RD estimates corresponding to equation (1) for the number of Democratic relative to opposition local officeholders *elected* in the year of presidential election $\tau \in \{1940, \dots, 1968\}$ itself, rather than over the subsequent election period. In the spirit of the placebo exercises in Table 4, the test asks whether a close Democratic presidential win in county c coincided with a contemporaneous gain in relative Democratic local officeholders. Such a contemporaneous effect would suggest that the downstream results in Table 2 operate in part through an incumbent-officeholder channel, of the kind examined in columns 1–2 of Table 6. Estimates are small and statistically indistinguishable from zero under both linear (column 1) and quadratic (column 2) running polynomials, based on the MSE-optimal bandwidth from Calonico et al. (2014). All regressions include (election) year fixed effects, state fixed effects, quadratic polynomials in county longitude and latitude, and the total number of local officeholders elected in τ . Standard errors are clustered at the county level and shown in parentheses. Significance levels are denoted by * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B.5: Dynamic Effects: Relative Changes in Democratic Performance Over Time

Dependent Variable:	$\Delta_{\tau \rightarrow t}$ in Dem. – Opp. [...]					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	(a) Outcome Measure: Local Officeholders					
Democrat Won County in Election τ	0.031 (0.025)	0.056** (0.023)	0.074*** (0.020)	0.077*** (0.020)	0.065*** (0.021)	0.068** (0.029)
Control outcome mean	0.14	0.13	0.11	0.11	0.12	0.12
Observations	16,015	17,912	19,151	21,176	21,492	21,857
	(b) Outcome Measure: Presidential Voters					
Democrat Won County in Election τ	1266.61** (609.7)	1196.71** (523.4)	1223.46** (559.3)	1900.37*** (609.1)	2694.00*** (666.1)	2962.83*** (851.3)
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
County unit FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Control for total value in $t - 1$	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
% Vote Margin $_{c\tau} \in (0, x]$	$x = 15$	$x = 20$	$x = 25$	$x = 50$	$x = 75$	$x = 100$
Control outcome mean	-188.95	-742.81	-1093.46	-1733.10	-2647.22	-3386.58
Observations	15,901	17,772	18,997	20,971	21,255	21,611

Notes: This table reports bias-corrected local-polynomial RD estimates for number of Democratic (a) local officeholders and (b) presidential voters in election $\tau + y \equiv t$, $y \geq 1$ as compared to the party's primary opposition in presidential election $\tau \in \{1940, \dots, 1968\}$, relative to $y \geq 0$. Treatment based on a county's first sample election with a (close) Democratic win (limited to $V_{c\tau} \in [0, x]$, where $x = \{15, 20, 25, 50, 75, 100\}$ is varied by column). All regressions include (election) year fixed effects, county fixed effects (based on fixed-boundary units), and total local officeholders (panel a) and presidential votes (panel b) in $t - 1$. Standard errors are clustered at the county level and shown in parentheses. Significance levels are denoted by * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table B.6: Electoral College Footprint of the Winner Premium by Election τ

Election $\tau + 1$	Close Dem. wins in τ	Dem. elect. votes (actual)	Additive premium (2,118 votes per win)			Proportional premium (9.1 per 100 votes)		
			Premium votes	Pivotal states	Dem. elect. votes (c.f.)	Premium votes	Pivotal states	Dem. elect. votes (c.f.)
1944	461	432	976,575	7	388	1,037,994	5	362
1948	395	303	836,762	8	218	922,513	3	243
1952	561	89	1,188,414	1	79	1,617,309	1	79
1956	286	73	605,858	2	46	825,722	2	46
1960	308	303	652,462	5	246	572,728	4	256
1964	458	486	970,220	1	482	1,470,018	0	486
1968	611	191	1,294,333	0	191	950,309	1	166
1972	425	17	900,313	0	17	1,431,456	0	17

Notes: This table traces the electoral college footprint of the winner premium across the presidential elections of 1944–1972. Each county that narrowly won the presidential vote in election τ (within the MSE-optimal bandwidth of column 1 of Table 2) is credited with the estimated premium, which is then removed from its Democratic-minus-opposition presidential vote lead in $\tau + 1$ before votes are re-aggregated to state totals. A state is counted as *pivotal* if Democrats carried it but would not have absent the premium. The *additive* accounting credits each close winner the same 2,118 net votes (the column-1 estimate); the *proportional* accounting credits 9.1 percent of the county’s own turnout (the same estimate expressed per 100 votes cast), scaling the premium to local electorate size in a manner analogous to weighting counties by their electoral significance. “Premium votes” reports the total premium credited across all close winners, and “Pivotal states” the number of states that flip once it is removed. “Dem. elect. votes (actual)” is the Democratic candidate’s actual national electoral-vote total; “Dem. elect. votes (c.f.)” is the counterfactual total after the premium is removed—the actual total less the (era-appropriate) electoral votes of the pivotal states. A counterfactual total set in **bold** falls below the contemporaneous electoral college majority (266 through 1956, 269 in 1960, 270 from 1964), meaning that removing the premium reverses the Democrat’s electoral college majority; this occurs only in the two closely contested elections Democrats won, 1948 (Truman) and 1960 (Kennedy). In both, the additive accounting hands the opposition an outright majority, while the proportional accounting leaves no candidate with a majority. The exercise is illustrative and hinges on strong all-else-equal assumptions.

C A Theory of Elections and Strategic Coordination

Political parties are composed of different *political investors*. These include voters, activists, donors, party operatives—anyone with resources to invest (e.g., labor, money, time, future votes). In principle, agents would like to direct resources to where the political fundamentals are relatively strong for the party. Yet, payoffs depend not only on the environment but also on whether others also invest in the same location. Indeed, coordination itself generates value: concentrating investment enhances impact, while withholding together conserves resources and avoids dispersion, freeing capacity to concentrate investment elsewhere.

Let there be a unit mass of agents $i \in [0, 1]$ each choosing an action, $a_i \in \{I, W\}$, where I denotes political investment in some representative location and W denotes withholding.¹ Let $a = \int_0^1 \mathbb{1}\{a_i = I\} di$ denote the aggregate level of political investment in the location. The net payoff from investing (relative to withholding) depends on a political fundamental $\theta \in \mathbb{R}$ and on the aggregate investment of others:

$$\pi(\theta, a),$$

which is assumed to satisfy the following conditions:

- (A1) π is strictly increasing in θ : stronger political fundamentals raise the return to investment.
- (A2) π is strictly increasing in a : agents' investment choices are strategic complements.
- (A3) Dominance regions exist: there exist $\underline{\theta}, \bar{\theta}$ such that $\pi(\underline{\theta}, 1) < 0$ and $\pi(\bar{\theta}, 0) > 0$. That is, when fundamentals are sufficiently weak, withholding dominates regardless of what others do; when sufficiently strong, investing dominates.

Additionally, I assume that when fundamentals are neither favorable nor unfavorable, an agent who considers all possible levels of others' investment to be equally likely has no reason to prefer investing over withholding:

- (A4) Political fundamentals are favorable for the party if and only if $\theta > 0$. At the boundary $\theta = 0$, the net payoff from investment, averaged over all possible levels of aggregate investment, is zero: $\int_0^1 \pi(0, a) da = 0$.

¹I model this as a one-location, one-shot game, but it could just as well be either an M -location static game, or a single stage of a repeated game that ends once all agents choose I for a given location.

Benchmark with No Private Information. I begin with the case where agents can rely solely on public information to infer political fundamentals, with $\theta = \alpha V$, $\alpha > 0$, where V is the party's recent electoral margin in the representative location.

Given complete information, there are three cases. Define $\bar{V}$ by $\pi(\alpha\bar{V}, 0) = 0$ and $\underline{V}$ by $\pi(\alpha\underline{V}, 1) = 0$, with $\underline{V} < \bar{V}$ following from (A1)–(A3). Then: (i) if $V > \bar{V}$, all agents invest in the unique equilibrium; (ii) if $V < \underline{V}$, all agents withhold in the unique equilibrium; and (iii) if $V \in [\underline{V}, \bar{V}]$, both outcomes are equilibria. In other words, if the political fundamentals are sufficiently strong, agents always invest; if they are weak, agents withhold.

Equilibrium Selection. In the multiplicity region $V \in [\underline{V}, \bar{V}]$, a natural selection criterion evaluates each equilibrium against the payoff an agent would expect under maximal strategic uncertainty—a uniform belief over a . This selects the all-invest equilibrium whenever $\int_0^1 \pi(\alpha V, a) da > 0$. Because π is strictly increasing in θ and condition (A4) holds, the pivot is

$$V^* = 0.$$

That is, in the multiplicity region, the selected equilibrium involves investment in the location when its vote margin is positive and withholding when it is negative.

Global Game with Private Information. Now suppose that agents rely on public information, in the form of recent election margins V , as well as on private information to infer local political fundamentals. Whereas V reflects the party's observable standing in the location, overall fundamentals also comprise an unobservable component that captures short-run local conditions between elections. Formally, the total fundamental in the representative location is

$$\theta = \alpha V + u,$$

where u is a residual deviation from the party's publicly-observed electoral standing. The key assumption is that, across a given location, the expected value of this deviation is zero: because its mean is itself unobservable to agents, they treat V as an unbiased proxy for local fundamentals on average. Formally,

$$u \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_u^2),$$

where σ_u^2 governs the residual uncertainty about fundamentals that remains after observing the party's vote margin.

A maintained assumption of the model is that σ_u is small: recent vote margins are on average a reliable (smooth) proxy for local fundamentals. This is most plausible in

relatively stable electoral periods—such as the years immediately following an election, or more broadly in eras without large systematic shocks that shift local political environments across many places simultaneously. In practice, this assumption would be violated by events such as major wars, economic crises, or others that induce correlated swings in local conditions. Importantly, this assumption motivates the paper’s empirical focus on the period 1940–1968, which falls between the large leftward swing of 1932–1936 and the rightward shift beginning in 1972.

Each agent i observes a noisy private signal of this residual factor,

$$s_i = u + \varepsilon_i, \quad \varepsilon_i \stackrel{\text{iid}}{\sim} \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2),$$

which represents their read of or exposure to u on top of V , and therefore of the total fundamental in the location, $\theta = \alpha V + u$. The central assumption is that, although signals s_i are idiosyncratic across agents, they are nonetheless correlated through u . In turn, one’s own signal reveals information about others’ signals, with the correlation stronger where party organizations and activist networks repeat and amplify the result, leaving less to idiosyncratic local reads ($\sigma \downarrow 0$).

Timing. The timing of the game under incomplete information takes place as follows:

1. Nature draws u . Each agent observes the party’s vote margin V in the representative location, as well as a private signal $s_i = u + \varepsilon_i$.
2. Each agent forms beliefs about the political fundamentals of the location $\theta = \alpha V + u$ and about the aggregate investment of others.
3. Agents privately choose whether to invest (I) or withhold (W) in the location. Payoffs are realized.

Bayesian updating gives a posterior mean of u for agent i given signal s_i of

$$\mathbb{E}(u \mid s_i) = A s_i, \quad A = \frac{\sigma_u^2}{\sigma_u^2 + \sigma^2} \in (0, 1),$$

where A is the weight on the private signal relative to the agent’s prior. Each agent’s perceived fundamental is therefore

$$\mathbb{E}(\theta \mid V, s_i) = \alpha V + A s_i.$$

In other words, a stronger private signal s_i raises an agent’s assessment of political fundamentals and—because signals are correlated through u —the perceived likelihood that other agents will invest.

I now turn to equilibrium. Suppose each agent plays a cutoff strategy, investing only if s_i is sufficiently strong. Given a common threshold s^* , the proportion of agents investing conditional on the true state u is

$$a(u, s^*) = 1 - \Phi\left(\frac{s^* - u}{\sigma}\right),$$

and an agent with signal s_i evaluates the expected net benefit of investing as

$$\Delta(s_i, V, s^*) = \mathbb{E}[\pi(\alpha V + u, a(u, s^*)) \mid s_i].$$

By (A1)–(A2), a stronger signal s_i raises both the agent's assessment of fundamentals and the expected proportion of others investing. Thus Δ is strictly increasing in s_i , and each agent's best response is a cutoff strategy. The global games framework (Carlsson and van Damme, 1993; Morris and Shin, 1998, 2003) then yields a unique equilibrium in threshold strategies for every finite $\sigma > 0$.

Proposition 1. *Under (A1)–(A3), for any vote margin V and any finite $\sigma > 0$, there exists a unique Bayesian Nash equilibrium in monotone cutoff strategies. The common threshold $s^*(V)$ solves the indifference condition*

$$\mathbb{E}[\pi(\alpha V + u, a(u, s^*(V))) \mid s_i = s^*(V)] = 0, \quad (\text{C.1})$$

with $s^*(V)$ strictly decreasing in V .

Proof. Throughout, the posterior of u given signal s_i is $u \mid s_i \sim \mathcal{N}(As_i, A\sigma^2)$, where $A = \sigma_u^2/(\sigma_u^2 + \sigma^2)$. Given a common threshold t , the proportion of agents investing conditional on the true state u is $a(u, t) = 1 - \Phi\left(\frac{t-u}{\sigma}\right)$, and the expected net benefit from investing for agent i with signal s_i is

$$\Delta(s_i, V, t) = \mathbb{E}\left[\pi\left(\alpha V + u, 1 - \Phi\left(\frac{t-u}{\sigma}\right)\right) \mid s_i\right].$$

Step 1: Best response is a unique threshold. Fix vote margin V and a candidate common threshold t . A higher s_i shifts the posterior of u upward (since $\mathbb{E}[u \mid s_i] = As_i$), raising both $\alpha V + u$ and $a(u, t) = 1 - \Phi\left(\frac{t-u}{\sigma}\right)$ in probability. By (A1)–(A2), π is strictly increasing in both arguments, so $\Delta(s_i, V, t)$ is strictly increasing in s_i . Moreover, as $s_i \rightarrow \infty$, the posterior concentrates on large u , such that $\theta \rightarrow \infty$ and $a \rightarrow 1$, giving $\Delta \rightarrow \infty$ by (A3). Similarly, as $s_i \rightarrow -\infty$, $\theta \rightarrow -\infty$ and $a \rightarrow 0$, giving $\Delta \rightarrow -\infty$

by (A3). Single crossing thus follows from the intermediate value theorem, giving a unique solution $s^*(V, t)$ such that $\Delta(s^*(V, t), V, t) = 0$, with investment if and only if $s_i \geq s^*(V, t)$.

Step 2: Best response is strictly increasing in the common threshold. Fix s_i and let $t' > t$. Then $a(u, t') < a(u, t)$ for every u , since Φ is strictly increasing. By (A2), $\pi(\alpha V + u, a(u, t')) < \pi(\alpha V + u, a(u, t))$ for every u , so $\Delta(s_i, V, t') < \Delta(s_i, V, t)$.

Since $\Delta(s^*(V, t), V, t) = 0$, it follows that $\Delta(s^*(V, t), V, t') < 0$. Because Δ is strictly increasing in s_i with $\Delta \rightarrow \infty$, restoring indifference requires $s^*(V, t') > s^*(V, t)$. Continuity of $s^*(V, t)$ in t follows from continuity of Δ in all arguments combined with strict monotonicity in s_i .

Step 3: Iterated deletion of dominated strategies. The sequence of iterated deletion $k = 0, 1, \dots$ takes place as follows. I begin with extreme conjectures, where all agents invest if $t = -\infty$ and no agents invest if $t = \infty$. These give lower and upper best response strategies, respectively, of

$$\underline{s}^{k=0} = s^*(V, t = -\infty), \quad \bar{s}^{k=0} = s^*(V, t = \infty).$$

Iterating best responses from those extremes gives

$$\underline{s}^{k+1} = s^*(V, \underline{s}^k), \quad \bar{s}^{k+1} = s^*(V, \bar{s}^k).$$

Because the best response $s^*(V, t)$ is strictly increasing and continuous in t , the sequences are monotone:

$$\underline{s}^{k=0} \leq \underline{s}^{k=1} \leq \dots, \quad \bar{s}^{k=0} \geq \bar{s}^{k=1} \geq \dots,$$

and the order $\underline{s}^k \leq \bar{s}^k$ is preserved at each step: if $\underline{s}^k \leq \bar{s}^k$, then by strict monotonicity of $s^*(V, \cdot)$,

$$\underline{s}^{k+1} = s^*(V, \underline{s}^k) \leq s^*(V, \bar{s}^k) = \bar{s}^{k+1}.$$

Each sequence is monotone and bounded—the lower sequence above by $\bar{s}^0$, the upper sequence below by $\underline{s}^0$ —so by the monotone bounded sequence theorem, both converge:

$$\underline{s}^k \uparrow \underline{s}, \quad \bar{s}^k \downarrow \bar{s},$$

with $\underline{s} \leq \bar{s}$. By continuity of $s^*(V, t)$ in t , the limits are fixed points of the best response

map:

$$\underline{s} = s^*(V, \underline{s}), \quad \bar{s} = s^*(V, \bar{s}).$$

The payoff exhibits strict monotonicity in the fundamental (A1) and in the aggregate action (A2), with dominance regions (A3), single crossing of Δ in signals (Step 1), and atomless Gaussian private noise. These are the standard conditions under which the global games framework yields a unique equilibrium in monotone cutoff strategies (Carlsson and van Damme, 1993; Morris and Shin, 1998, 2003). The equilibrium threshold is therefore unique, so $\underline{s} = \bar{s} = s^*(V)$.

Step 4: $s^*(V)$ is strictly decreasing in V . For $V' > V$, condition (A1) gives $\pi(\alpha V' + u, a) > \pi(\alpha V + u, a)$ for every (u, a) , so $\Delta(s_i, V', t) > \Delta(s_i, V, t)$ for every s_i and t . Hence $s^*(V', t) < s^*(V, t)$ for every t : the entire best response map shifts down. The unique fixed points therefore satisfy $s^*(V') \neq s^*(V)$, since if some s were a fixed point of both maps, we would have $s = s^*(V', s) < s^*(V, s) = s$, a contradiction. Combined with the pointwise ordering of the maps, this gives $s^*(V') < s^*(V)$. $\square$

In other words, as the party vote margin V increases, weaker signals suffice to trigger individual political investment. As V decreases, stronger signals are needed. In political terms, when a location leans more toward the party electorally, agents are more easily persuaded to invest there.

In the limit as private signals become precise ($\sigma \downarrow 0$), the threshold agent's posterior concentrates on the true state, and the proportion of agents investing becomes a step function of u around s^* . The Morris and Shin (2003) Laplacian property then implies that the threshold agent holds a uniform belief over $a \in [0, 1]$, so the threshold fundamental θ^* solves $\int_0^1 \pi(\theta^*, a) da = 0$, which by condition (A4) gives $\theta^* = 0$.

Proposition 2. *Under Proposition 1, the equilibrium political investment probability at party vote margin V is*

$$q(V) = 1 - \Phi \left(\frac{s^*(V)}{\sqrt{\sigma_u^2 + \sigma^2}} \right),$$

with $q(V)$ strictly increasing in V .

- (i) For $\sigma \downarrow 0$, $q(V) \rightarrow \Phi \left(\frac{\alpha V}{\sigma_u} \right)$.
- (ii) For $\sigma \downarrow 0$ and $\sigma_u \downarrow 0$, $q(V) \rightarrow \mathbb{1}\{V > 0\}$.

Proof. Since $s_i = u + \varepsilon_i$ with $u \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_u^2)$ and $\varepsilon_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2)$ independent, $s_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_u^2 + \sigma^2)$, and $q(V) = \Pr(s_i \geq s^*(V)) = 1 - \Phi\left(\frac{s^*(V)}{\sqrt{\sigma_u^2 + \sigma^2}}\right)$ follows from the Normal CDF. $\frac{\partial q}{\partial V} > 0$ follows from Proposition 1, since $s^*(V)$ is strictly decreasing in V .

For part (i), the Laplacian property of Morris and Shin (2003) applies—its conditions are satisfied here, since $a(u, s^*)$ is continuous and strictly increasing in u , payoffs are continuous and strictly monotone, and noise is atomless. Specifically, as $\sigma \downarrow 0$, the threshold agent’s belief about the proportion of agents investing converges to Uniform $[0, 1]$. The indifference condition therefore converges to $\int_0^1 \pi(\theta^*, a) da = 0$, where $\theta^* = \alpha V + s^*(V)$ is the threshold fundamental. By condition (A4), $\theta^* = 0$, which gives $s^*(V) \rightarrow -\alpha V$. The investment probability then converges to

$$\lim_{\sigma \rightarrow 0} q(V) = 1 - \Phi\left(\frac{-\alpha V}{\sigma_u}\right) = \Phi\left(\frac{\alpha V}{\sigma_u}\right).$$

Lastly, part (ii) follows from the Normal CDF: for $\Phi(x/y)$, as $y \rightarrow 0$, $\Phi(x/y) \rightarrow \mathbb{1}\{x > 0\} + \frac{1}{2}\mathbb{1}\{x = 0\}$. $\square$

In other words, private and public information are complementary in the model. For finite σ and σ_u , higher party vote margins V steadily induce investor concentration in the location. As private signals become more reliable ($\sigma \downarrow 0$), the equilibrium investment probability takes on an S-shaped form through $V = 0$, with a higher probability for $V > 0$ and a low probability for $V < 0$. Under the maintained assumption that σ_u is small—as in stable electoral periods where recent vote margins closely track local fundamentals—this distribution approximates a step-function at $V = 0$: agents invest where the party’s vote margins are positive and withhold where they are negative, mirroring the selected outcome of the benchmark game.

Signal Precision and the Sharpness of the Investment Response. The two extremes of σ bracket the model’s implications for how sharply investment responds to a marginal win.

Corollary 1. *Compare two locations that differ only in the precision of private signals. In the location where signals are precise ($\sigma \downarrow 0$), the investment probability converges to $\Phi(\alpha V/\sigma_u)$, whose slope at $V = 0$ is $\alpha/(\sigma_u\sqrt{2\pi})$; as $\sigma_u \downarrow 0$ this slope diverges and $q(V)$ approaches a step function at $V = 0$. In the location where signals are uninformative ($\sigma \rightarrow \infty$), agents place no weight on private information ($A \rightarrow 0$) and*

behavior converges to the benchmark game above, in which the vote margin selects among equilibria only within the multiplicity region $[V, \bar{V}]$. The response of investment to a marginal win is therefore sharper where private signals are more precise.

Proof. The $\sigma \downarrow 0$ limit follows from Proposition 2(i); differentiating $\Phi(\alpha V/\sigma_u)$ with respect to V and evaluating at $V = 0$ gives $\alpha\phi(0)/\sigma_u = \alpha/(\sigma_u\sqrt{2\pi})$, which is decreasing in σ_u and diverges as $\sigma_u \downarrow 0$, establishing Proposition 2(ii). For the opposite extreme, $A = \sigma_u^2/(\sigma_u^2 + \sigma^2) \rightarrow 0$ as $\sigma \rightarrow \infty$, so $\mathbb{E}(\theta \mid V, s_i) \rightarrow \alpha V$ for every s_i : private signals carry no weight in the posterior and agents condition on V alone, which is the benchmark case above. $\square$

Corollary 1 compares the two extremes of σ ; the interior case is not characterized in closed form, since $s^*(V)$ is defined implicitly by (C.1) and its dependence on σ operates through both the posterior mean and the perceived distribution of a . The extremes nonetheless deliver an empirical prediction of interest: a marginal win produces a sharper break in investment in high-signal places than in low-signal places. Insofar as party organizations, activist networks, and allied institutions circulate the result and align what local actors know, such places are where private signals are most precise. This result formally motivates the corresponding sample splits in the empirical analysis (in Table 6).

Two Channels, One Signal. Finally, it is worth separating the two roles that the vote margin plays in the model; indeed, they carry different empirical signatures. Because $\theta = \alpha V + u$, the margin is directly informative about fundamentals: by (A1), a higher V raises the return to investment for any belief about a , and this channel operates smoothly in V . But the margin also coordinates. Through $s^*(V)$ and the correlation of signals in u , a higher V raises each agent's belief that others will invest, and by (A2) this raises the return to investment again. It is this second channel, operating through beliefs about others' behavior rather than about fundamentals, that concentrates the response at $V = 0$; the pivot of the benchmark selection criterion, the limit of the threshold $s^*(V) \rightarrow -\alpha V$, and the step function of Proposition 2(ii) all locate the break precisely at the sign change of the margin, not elsewhere in its support.

The distinction matters for interpretation. A purely informational account predicts that investment responds to *how much* a party won by, with no special role for the sign of

the margin. The coordination account predicts a discontinuity at zero, where a vanishingly small change in the margin flips the publicly observed ranking. Both channels are present here, and both work in the same direction. Yet, the discontinuity is the signature of only the second. This is what the regression discontinuity design in the body of the paper is meant to isolate, and why $V = 0$ —rather than any other point in the support of the margin—is the threshold of interest.